

QUIET DEPARTURES

written by
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FADE IN:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - GARAGE - NIGHT (LATE AUTUMN)

Late, and the building dark but for one bulb. VERN (60s) works alone at the open back of a hearse -- rolling a casket in, cinching the straps, three buckles checked twice, the old habit. He moves slow and sure, a body that has done this so long it no longer has to ask him.

He fills a dented thermos from a machine that has made bad coffee since the mill was still running. On the wall, a photograph gone amber: three men in front of this building, decades back. Vern is one of them. He does not look at it. He stopped looking at it a long time ago.

He climbs in. Sits a moment, both hands on the wheel, eyes closed -- a man at the start of a road he has driven ten thousand times and would give a great deal never to drive again.

Then he opens his eyes, and puts it in gear.

I/E. HEARSE - NIGHT

Fog on a river road -- black water off to one side, the Ohio, wide and slow, the state line running along the far bank of it. Through the windshield of a HEARSE, the world arrives slow and gray.

VERN drives. Steady hands, the radio low, the thermos steaming in the cupholder, the casket riding quiet behind him. He drives like a man who has done this a thousand times. Because he has.

The road unspools ahead into the dark. Bare trees. No other headlights -- just the hum of the engine, the low radio, and the fog opening and closing behind him.

EXT. STATE LINE - NIGHT

Ahead, out on the highway, a state weigh station sits at the edge of the road -- lit sodium-yellow, the kind the long trucks pull into and idle and wait. The hearse is not a truck. It is nobody's freight, subject to nobody's scale. It holds its lane and rolls on past, unweighed and unremarked -- the way the dead move everywhere.

Nobody stops a man carrying the dead. Nobody ever has.

The hearse crosses the bridge, over the water, into Ohio and the dark.

I/E. HEARSE - CONTINUOUS

An empty stretch of road. Then, for no reason at all, the hearse slows. Eases onto the shoulder. Stops.

Vern sits. Breathes. Something crosses his face -- a shadow, a question. His hand drifts to his chest. Rests there.

A long beat.

Then it eases. Whatever it was, it lets go. He works his jaw, puts the car in gear, pulls back onto the road.

The taillights shrink. The fog takes them.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - VIEWING ROOM - DAY

The same darkness, warmed. Lamplight and lilies. An open casket. An organ somewhere, playing low. This is the temperature of grief. This room knows it well.

And moving through it, unhurried, is MARV COYLE (52) -- dark suit, soft voice, the gentlest hands in three counties. Watch him work.

A big man in a too-tight collar stands rigid at the casket, jaw locked -- a man told his whole life that men don't. Marv does not tell him it's all right. He sets a hand on the man's shoulder and says something low we do not hear, and the man laughs, a wet, startled bark, and the lock breaks. Marv is already moving on before the tears come, leaving him his dignity.

A little girl, six maybe, clings to her mother's leg, frightened of the still figure in the box. Marv crouches to her height. Whatever he says, she goes from terror to solemn wonder -- and reaches out, and touches the dead man's folded hands, and is not afraid.

An old friend of the widow's hovers near the guest book, wringing a program to pulp, stuck.

FRIEND

I don't know what to say to
her, Marv. I never know what to
say.

MARV

You don't have to say the right thing. Nobody's got the right thing. You just have to be the one who came -- and you already did the hard part.

She nods like he has handed her a lamp in the dark, and goes to her friend with her shoulders down from around her ears.

Three people. Three exact readings. Three small mercies -- and not one of them will remember it was Marv who gave it. The most necessary man in this county, and the most invisible. A room full of people he is holding up, and not one of them holding him.

Then, at the far side of the room, RUTH (70s). And something in Marv settles. He does not cross to her the way he crossed to the others -- reading, deploying, giving. He just crosses to her. Sits. Knee to knee. With Ruth he is not the undertaker of three counties; he is a boy she once held by the hand, and they both know it. One of his hands rests on her forearm. Every ounce of the man is turned toward her.

MARV

Take all the time you need,
Ruth. He's not going anywhere.

(a small smile)
That's the one mercy of my
business. Nobody's ever in a
hurry but the living.

Ruth almost smiles. Almost.

RUTH

I don't know how to do the
after, Marv. The quiet part.

MARV

Nobody does. That's the secret
nobody tells you.

(beat)
You don't do it. You get up
tomorrow, and I'll be right
here, and we'll do tomorrow.
That's all it ever is.

Ruth nods. Draws on her gloves, one and then the other. Then, carefully, a question with an edge to it:

RUTH

How much do I owe you. For all of it.

MARV

Ruth. Bury your husband. We'll talk about the small things when the big thing's done.

She rises. At the door she turns and takes him in -- the whole of him.

RUTH

You're a good man, Marv Coyle.

And she's gone.

Hold on Marv. Alone now, among the flowers. The warmth leaves his face by slow degrees, the way heat leaves a stone after dark.

And no one is left in the room to need him.

He straightens a single lily that did not need straightening. Lets his hand fall.

CUT TO:

INT. A COMPANY HOUSE - BEDROOM - NIGHT

Three in the morning. A cramped bedroom in a house that has not been painted since the mill closed. An old woman has died in the bed she shared for fifty years, and her husband -- ninety if he is a day -- sits in a chair drawn up beside her in his undershirt, holding her hand, and will not let it go.

Marv works quietly at the far side of the bed with a young man from the family, unfolding the cot. And nothing about the mechanics of it is gentle. The dead are heavy, and the doorways are narrow, and gravity does not make exceptions for grief. It is close, awkward, breathless work, and Marv has done it countless times, in the dark, for people who will never once in their lives picture him doing it.

The old man says, to no one, that she was cold. That he should have got another blanket on her. Marv stops. Comes around the bed. Crouches down to the old man's level -- the way he crouched to the frightened girl at the casket -- and takes the old man's free hand in both of his.

MARV

(low, certain)

She wasn't cold, Mr. Danko. Not with you right there. A body gets cold. She was gone on ahead of it a good while before that -- somewhere warm -- and she went knowin' exactly whose hand was in hers. That's not a small thing. That's the whole thing there is.

And the old man lets go of her hand at last, because Marv has given him somewhere else to set it down. They lift her together, the grandson and the undertaker, and carry her out through the narrow house into the cold. Marv slides the cot into the back of the hearse and shuts the door soft, and stands a moment in the empty street, alone with the one kind of work nobody ever sees him do. Then he drives her home.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - MARV'S OFFICE - DAY

A cramped office. Dark wood, three generations of framed licenses going yellow on the wall, a ledger the size of a Bible. Across the desk sits EARL PRUITT (60s) -- millwright's hands, thirty years in the hot end of the Weirton works, and nothing to put them to now. He turns his cap over and over in them and cannot quite meet Marv's eye.

EARL

I prepaid the whole thing back in oh-nine. Casket, the plot, the stone. But Betty and me are movin' across the river to Steubenville, by her sister, and there's a place over there does it for less, and money bein' what it is...

I'm sorry, Marv. I am.

It is the third one this season. The Hendersons went to a cremation outfit off the interstate. The Yost boy drove his mother back over to Ohio to bury her cheap. The town is leaving Marv Coyle a prepaid plan at a time, packing itself up across the river where even the dying comes cheaper. He knows the shape of it by now.

And still Marv doesn't flinch. If anything, the warmth comes

up brighter.

MARV

Earl. You don't apologize to
me. Not ever.

He's already opening the ledger. The pen finds the line --
and stops there. One breath. Earl, deep in his cap, does not
see it. Then Marv writes.

MARV (CONT'D)

You take care of your family.
That is the whole job, start to
finish. Your money'll be back
to you inside the month, Earl.
Take it where you please.
Fair's fair.

Earl stares at him like a man who expected a fight and got
absolution instead.

EARL

You're about the last decent
man in this town. You know
that?

Marv gives him the smile. It is warm, and true, and worn as
smooth as a stair. Even Marv may not know anymore where the
craft ends and the man begins.

MARV

Tell Betty I said hello.

Earl goes. The smile holds one beat past the door -- then
leaves Marv's face entirely. He finds the line in the column
where Earl Pruitt has sat since two thousand nine, and
strikes it out, and carries the rest to the foot of the
page. It is a smaller number than it was this morning, and
it will not get bigger. He sits with it a moment. Then he
closes the book.

CUT TO:

EXT. WEIRTON - MAIN STREET - DUSK

Marv drives the hearse back through town at the grey end of
the day, and the town gives him no reason to hurry. Half the
storefronts on Main are papered over. A hardware, a
five-and-dime, a lunch counter -- all dark, all a long time

dark, the signs still hung over doors that nobody opens. FOR LEASE gone yellow behind the glass. A traffic light works a dead intersection, patient, red to green to red, for no one at all. A town crew on a lift strings the municipal snowflakes pole to pole, same as every November, over the dark windows below.

And over all of it, up on the bench above the river, the mill. Weirton Steel. Miles of it -- the thing the whole town was poured around -- gone cold and silent now, rust the color of dried blood down the great sheds, the stacks that once ran day and night just standing against the sky the way a headstone stands. A town built to feed one furnace. And the furnace went out.

Marv has driven past it every day of his life, and he does not look at it anymore, the way you quit looking at a thing you cannot fix. He passes a knot of young men on a corner with nowhere in the world to be, and they watch the hearse roll by -- the one business left in this town, a man might tell you, that never once ran short of trade.

The river runs on past the dead works, brown and wide and indifferent, toward the Ohio bank on the far side. Marv drives home through the ruin of the place, and the ruin does not trouble him. It is just the weather he has always lived in.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - NIGHT

The place after hours, dark but for one desk lamp. Marv runs an adding machine. Tears off the tape. Reads it. Runs it again, as if the number might reconsider. It does not.

On the blotter the appointment book lies open to a week with nothing written in it. A town dying faster than it has in a generation, and not one of them can afford to do it in his rooms. He closes the book. Coyle & Son has stood on this corner since his grandfather's day, and he can feel it going out from under him now, slow and sure, the way a tide goes out.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Fluorescent hum. Stainless steel. A body under a sheet on the table, routine and unremarked. Marv eats a sandwich standing over the sink, still in shirt and tie.

He catches his own reflection in the dark glass of a cabinet. Straightens. And -- quietly, privately -- he practices. Soft eyes. The gentle tilt of the head. The face

he wears for the grieving. He runs it once. Adjusts. Runs it again. Perfect.

For no one.

Behind him, VERN shrugs into his coat, slow -- an old man at the end of a long day.

VERN
Keep talkin' to yourself like
that, Marv, somebody's liable
to lay you out on one of these
tables and never know the
difference.

MARV
(not turning)
Just keeping in practice.

Vern watches him a moment, the coat half on.

VERN
Thirty years I've watched you
get that face just right. For
everybody but yourself.

MARV
(light)
Somebody's got to do the
honors.

VERN
(a beat, quieter)
Mm. Somebody always does.

He works the coat the rest of the way on. And then, for just a moment, he stands there not leaving -- looking around the room like a man trying to remember why he came into it. Then it passes.

VERN (CONT'D)
Go on home. Them dead'll keep
till mornin'. They always do.

Marv turns. Something passes between these two men -- thirty years of it, none of it ever once said out loud.

MARV

Night, Vern. Lock the back.

VERN

Always do.

Vern goes. The back door opens on cold dark, and closes. Outside, an engine turns over, pulls away.

Marv stands alone in the hum. He does not know it is the last time he will see the man alive.

He reaches over and draws the sheet a little straighter over the body. Habit. Care. The very same gesture as the lily.

CUT TO:

EXT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - MORNING

Gray morning, the light only just coming up -- winter is close now. Vern's old truck already sits in the lot, its windshield frosted over: it has stood here since well before dawn. Vern is always first in -- hours before Marv, thirty years running, an old man who long ago stopped sleeping much and liked the building best when it was only him, the quiet, and the dead. MARV comes up the walk balancing TWO paper coffees and a ring of keys, doing the small clumsy dance of a man with no free hand.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - CONTINUOUS

He shoulders in, already talking.

MARV

Brought you the burnt one, the way you like it. Still say it tastes like a tire fire, but a man's got a right to his--

He stops.

VERN is on the floor by the table. Collapsed mid-task, a cloth still in one hand. Gone a while now -- since before the light, by the stillness of him. He came in before dawn, the way he always did, and somewhere in the dark and the quiet his heart simply stopped -- the same hand that reached for his chest once, on a dark road, come back to finish the sentence. The room is very quiet.

The coffees go down on the counter -- set down fast, forgotten. Marv is across the room and on his knees before

he has decided to move, two fingers going to the side of Vern's throat, the back of his hand to the gray cheek. He has done this more times than he could ever count. He knows before he touches. But he touches anyway -- and the cold under his fingers finishes the sentence: hours ago. Nothing to be done, and nothing to be done quickly.

He lowers himself the rest of the way to the floor beside his friend. Does not shake him. Does not call out. Just looks at him, a long while.

Then his hands begin to move -- the old habit, the one tenderness he has ever fully trusted. He straightens Vern's collar. Smooths the thin hair back into place. Composing him, the way he has composed a thousand strangers.

MARV (CONT'D)

(barely)

...You couldn't wait for me to
get the coffee?

The two cups steam on the counter, side by side, and go cold.

CUT TO:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

Later. The others have come and gone -- the county man, the forms that turn a person into a case number. Now it is only Marv, and Vern on the table.

And Marv does the thing no man should have to do: he prepares his own. The hands Vern trained, working now on Vern. Very gentle. Very exact. He gives this man every small kindness he has given ten thousand strangers -- and for the first time in longer than he can remember, the face he wears is not a performance. There is no one here to perform for. There is only grief, plain and unrehearsed, doing its slow work through his hands.

For a while there is only the small clean sound of the work. Then Marv stops. He sets down what is in his hands, braces both palms on the edge of the table, and stands a moment, head bowed over the body of his friend. When he speaks, it is low -- the way you'd speak to a man you did not want to wake.

MARV

Thirty years. Every time I
asked after where you came

from, what you were before --
you had a way of setting it
down gentle and picking up
something else. I let you. A
man's quiet is his own, I
figured. I never once pushed on
it.

He pauses -- something in the set of that cold, familiar
face, or in his own tired mind.

MARV (CONT'D)
...Now I'm startin' to wonder
if you were keepin' me out. Or
keepin' me clean.

The dead keep their counsel. He gets no answer, and does not
really expect one. He finishes the work. Draws the sheet.
And turns out the light on the only man who ever knew the
whole of him, and told him nothing of himself in return.

CUT TO:

EXT. THREE SPRINGS CEMETERY - DAY

A hard little wind on the hill above town -- the Ohio River
a gray seam below, and beyond it the dead stacks of the
Weirton mill, cold against a colder sky. A handful of
mourners, no more -- an old man's whole account come due,
and this is the balance of it. A MINISTER reads the words.
They are the same words Marv has heard read over more graves
than he can count.

Only today Marv stands in front. On the other side of it.
And it is a strange and terrible thing: the one man in this
county who knows exactly what to say to the grieving has no
one to say it to him. No one reaches for his arm. He is the
comforter; there is no comfort pointed his way, and he would
not know where to put it if there were.

He keeps his face still. He is good at faces.

At the edge of the little crowd, apart, stands a MAN we have
not seen -- sixties, dark overcoat, a good hat. Hands
folded. A stranger. And in a town this small, at a funeral,
a face nobody can place is its own quiet event: every other
soul here Marv has known his whole life. This one he has
never laid eyes on. This is DUTCH. He is not watching the
casket.

He is watching Marv.

Marv feels it, and glances over. For a moment the two men simply regard one another across the graves -- a long, flat beat, no nod, no sign, nothing offered. Then the man turns and goes, unhurried, the way a man leaves a place he has every right to be.

Marv watches him thread out through the headstones, and gone. He does not know the face -- and in thirty years he has known them all. That man came from somewhere else.

Wind takes the minister's last words. Dirt goes down on the box.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - MARV'S OFFICE - NIGHT

The desk lamp again. Marv in shirtsleeves, tie loosened, the ledger open. Beside it a small drift of window envelopes -- the kind of mail nobody opens twice. One is torn open: FINAL NOTICE, and a bank's name.

He works the adding machine. Studies the tape. Sets it down. Whichever way he works them, the numbers do not reach spring with the house still standing. A dying town ought to be good country for an undertaker. But the dying here have nothing left either -- the mill took that with it when it went -- and a man can lay his neighbors down for thirty years and still lose the roof over the room he does it in.

He sits with that. Then he gets up.

He crosses to Vern's corner -- a battered desk, a coat still on the hook, thirty years of a man in one square of a dark room. Marv stands over it like a trespasser. He is looking, though he could not say for what. Anything. Something to sell. Something to make a number move.

He opens the deep bottom drawer.

INSERT - THE DRAWER

Under a folded rag, a coffee can. Marv pries the lid. Cash -- banded, ordered, patient. More than an old embalmer ever carried home in a year of honest Fridays, and years of it laid by, and not one dollar of it ever near a bank.

BACK TO SCENE

Marv does not touch it. He looks at it. Then he lifts out the thing beneath it: a cheap prepaid phone, the kind sold in a blister pack at a gas station. Black. Silent. Dead, or off.

And beneath that -- a notebook. Not the funeral ledger. Vern's own hand, cramped and careful: dates, a column of figures, a mark against each. No names. No services. No dead. Just money, coming and going on its own private tide. A second set of books a man keeps for one reason only -- so that someone, someday, cannot say it never happened.

Marv turns the pages slowly. And a cold understanding settles over him, the way it settles over a man who has finally read his own house right. Of course Vern kept it here. Not at home, where a landlord, or the county man who comes for the effects of a man with no family, might turn it up. Here. A funeral home takes cash and asks no questions. Hearses come and go at every hour and no one blinks. A body is the one box in America nobody opens. The trade was never just Vern's cover for the thing. The trade was the thing that made it possible.

He should be afraid, and some cellar-level part of him is. But a man three months from losing everything his family built has a gift for the harmless explanation, and Marv reaches for his now -- half aloud, the way you gentle a spooked horse.

MARV

(quiet)

...You just kept it. That's all it is. Thirty years, no wife, no vices, nowhere to spend it, and never much trusted a bank. A careful man keeps his own. Good for you, Vern.

He almost believes it. He wants to, and wanting is nine-tenths of the way there.

He sets the notebook by Vern's desk calendar -- the paper kind, a box for every day. A notation stops him.

A date, this week. A time. Two words in Vern's cramped hand: PICKUP - MERCER.

Marv checks it against the funeral schedule. Flips a page. Flips back. There is no Mercer. No death called in, no family, no body, no service. A pickup with nothing to pick up.

He stands holding the two books, the legitimate one and the other, one in each hand. Weighing them.

Then -- because it is easier, because the other thing has edges he does not want to run his thumb along -- he closes the calendar. Whatever it was, it was Vern's, and Vern is gone. It will keep. Or it won't.

He puts the coffee can back in the drawer. He does not put it back all the way.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - RECEIVING DOOR - DAY

The trade door -- where the dead come in. A buzzer sounds. Marv opens it. A MAN stands in the gray afternoon: THE RUNNER (30s), windbreaker, a gym bag over one shoulder, working a piece of gum. He looks past Marv into the building like a man weighing a room he's been told is partly his.

RUNNER
You'd be the new fella.

MARV
(evenly -- not confirming
a thing)
...And who would you be?

RUNNER
Came for Vern. But Vern's not
around anymore, way I hear it.

He reads Marv's face, and the still room behind him, and finds his answer there.

RUNNER (CONT'D)
So it's you now. You the new
fella, or ain't you?

A beat. Marv decides to be.

MARV
...I guess I am.

RUNNER
Vern. Heard he passed. That's a
shame. Real steady hand, that
man.

MARV
He was that.

The Runner lets himself in, uninvited, and drifts through the prep area -- the steel tables, the drains -- with a proprietary ease that lifts the hair on Marv's arms.

He runs a thumb along a steel table, checks it, finds it spotless. Nods, like that tells him something.

RUNNER

Clean shop. Vern ran a clean shop. That's half of it right there -- nobody ever wonders about the clean ones.

(turning back, easy)
You do the work yourself? Or you got a fella comes in.

A test, dressed as small talk. Marv hears the floor under it -- the real question is how many hands touch the bodies. How many pairs of eyes.

MARV

Myself. Always myself. Vern taught me, and Vern didn't teach two.

RUNNER

Good. Keep it that way. One set of hands, one set of eyes -- that's how a thing like this gets to be old. Vern was old.

He drifts to the doorway of the garage bay. Looks at the hearse a while. Then, without turning:

RUNNER (CONT'D)

Missed a date this week. The Mercer pickup. That's why they sent me down -- see is the new fella squared away, or is he gonna be a problem.

So it has been only days. The dirt on Vern is barely settled, and already the machine has noticed the gap and sent someone to fill it. Marv says nothing. Lets it hang. The Runner takes the silence for the thing silence usually is between men like this.

RUNNER (CONT'D)

Happens. Man dies, things slip. But upstairs don't love a slip, y'follow. Gets 'em wonderin' -- is the new fella squared away.

Is he reliable. Is he steady.

MARV
(giving nothing)
I've buried this town thirty
years without one complaint.
You tell upstairs I don't miss
dates.

The Runner grins. He likes that.

RUNNER
So how d'you wanna do it. Same
as Vern? Or you got your own
way of things.

A trap with no floor under it. Marv does not know same as Vern from Adam. But he reads the man in front of him -- reads that the Runner wants easy, wants nothing new to learn, wants to be told the world has not changed.

MARV
(choosing the man's own
wish)
Why fix what isn't broke. Same
as Vern.

RUNNER
That's what I like to hear.

He unzips the gym bag and lays its contents out on the steel, unhurried, the way a man sets down tools he is not ashamed of: bricks, wrapped tight in plastic. Marv looks at them and keeps his face -- the practiced face -- professionally, perfectly still.

RUNNER (CONT'D)
Same as always. Some loads you
sit on and they come to you.
Some you run yourself -- the
phone tells you which, and
where, and when. You never
touch the count. Your end comes
back to you clean, paper in the
drawer, same as it always came
to Vern. You know the drill.

MARV
The drill.

The Runner pauses. Something flickers behind his eyes.

RUNNER

...Vern really didn't leave you
nothin' written down, huh.

There it is -- a thin blade of suspicion, and the whole room tilts toward an edge. One wrong syllable and Marv stops being the new fella and starts being a loose end. He reaches for the truest thing he owns and lays it down soft.

MARV

Vern trusted me with the dead
of this whole county. He didn't
need to write down what a man
already knows.

I'll take care of it. I always
take care of it. That's the
whole of what I do.

The Runner holds his eyes a moment. Then buys it -- because Marv sells it, and because the Runner would dearly like to go home.

RUNNER

...Yeah. Okay.

He zips the empty bag. At the door, he stops.

RUNNER (CONT'D)

Sorry again. About Vern. He was
steady.

And gone. Marv stands alone with the bricks laid out on the steel table where the dead are meant to lie. He does not touch them.

CUT TO:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

The bricks, still there. Marv sits on a stool across from them, keeping a kind of vigil -- the same stillness he would give a body. Hours in it, maybe.

At last he takes one up. Turns it in the light. Weighs it in his palm. He lifts a scalpel from the tray -- his

instruments -- and nicks the plastic. A little powder blooms at the seam.

He knows what it is. Everyone in this town, this year, has learned what it is. When the mill went dark it took the paychecks, and then the men, and then some quiet thing that had held the place upright -- and into that hollow this came flooding. The powder that fills his caskets now. The young ones. The ones whose mothers cannot look. Weirton poured steel for a hundred years; now the only thing it turns out in any number is the dead, and Marv Coyle is the man they are brought to.

He sets it back among the others and does a piece of arithmetic no funeral bill ever taught him.

A KNOCK -- the front. The living people's door.

CODY (O.S.)

Marv? It's Cody.

Marv moves -- fast, smooth, no wasted motion. Bricks into the bag, bag into the cold room, door drawn to. Scalpel down. By the time he reaches the front, his face has composed itself into the only face anyone here has ever seen him wear.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - FRONT HALL - CONTINUOUS

CODY (30), sheriff's deputy, out of uniform, holds a foil-covered dish in both hands like an offering. Open-faced, earnest -- a boy half raised by this building.

CODY

Mom made you the chicken thing.
The one with the -- she says
you'll know the one. Said no
man ought to be eatin'
funeral-home coffee for
Thanksgiving.

(a little helpless)
I know a casserole ain't much
against -- against all this.
But it's what we got.

Marv takes the warm dish. What moves in him now is not performance -- it is the last of the real thing, and it aches.

MARV

You tell your mother she's the
kindest woman in three
counties, and I'll deny I ever
said it.

Cody laughs -- and for a moment he is not a deputy at all but the boy who did his homework at the front desk while his mother cleaned these offices, who Marv taught to drive in the big Cadillac out back because it was the heaviest, safest thing on the lot. He has loved this quiet man like an uncle his whole life, and it is in everything he does not quite know how to say.

Then he works up his nerve for the harder thing.

CODY

He was just always around,
y'know? Vern. Like the
building. First real cold snap
of the year, and I keep waitin'
on him to come limpin' in
complainin' about his knees.
You don't ever figure the
building's gonna up and--

(lets it go)
...You doin' all right out
here? All by yourself now?

And here is the open door. Cody is the law. Cody loves him. One true sentence -- I'm in something, son, help me out of it -- and none of the rest need ever happen.

Marv feels the sentence rise in his chest. He looks at the boy holding the warmth of his mother's kitchen.

MARV

I'm all right, Cody.

The No that never gets said. Quiet as a held breath.

CODY

(let off the hook,
brightening)
Good. That's -- good. At least
the place is still standin',
huh. Good to know you're still
here.

MARV

Still here.

Cody raps the doorframe twice -- affection -- and goes. Marv stands with the warm dish in his hands and the poison in the cold room twenty feet behind him, and not one flicker of either thing reaches his face.

FADE OUT.

INT. RUTH'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

A small, tidy kitchen -- a widow's kitchen, everything in its place because there is too much time now to keep it that way. Over the stove, a bare hook -- the one Warren's cedar wreath hung on, forty Decembers running. RUTH pours coffee she never asked if Marv wanted. He sits at her table looking, for once, like a man being taken care of instead of the other way round.

RUTH
You look like hell, Marv.

MARV
And you look like a woman about
to tell me why.

RUTH
(sitting)
You buried Vern and then you
kept right on goin'. No day
off. No sittin' down. A man
does that, it's 'cause he can't
stand to be in a quiet room
with himself.

Marv smiles -- the real one, smaller than the work one.

MARV
That's a lot of diagnosis for
one cup of coffee.

RUTH
It's free. So's the refill.

A beat between them, easy, decades deep.

MARV
(quietly)
I'm all right, Ruth. Just been

a hard stretch.

RUTH

Mm. They come in stretches.

(a look, kind and level)
You come to me if this one gets
long. You hear? I can't do much
for anybody anymore. But I can
put coffee in front of a tired
man and tell him the truth.
That's a service too.

Marv holds her eyes a moment. He came here to look after
her. Somehow she is the one doing the looking after.

MARV

...Yes, ma'am.

He rises. At the door, coat half on --

RUTH

Marv. That fella at Vern's,
stood off at the back.
Overcoat. Never come up to the
grave, never signed the book.
You know him?

MARV

(truthfully)
No. Figured him for one of
Vern's, from the old days.

Ruth looks at him a moment longer than the question needs.

RUTH

Mm. Probably so. Funerals draw
strays.

She waves him off. The door. She stands a moment at the
window over the sink, watching him cross to the hearse. Then
she lets the curtain fall.

CUT TO:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

The bricks out on the steel again. And on the second table,

under a sheet, a BODY -- a transfer. An out-of-town deceased with no family within three hundred miles, routed to Marv the way freight gets routed.

And now, standing between the two tables, he lets the pieces close. The bricks the Runner left. A body no one is coming to claim or to grieve. And in Vern's cramped notebook, the same two words paired over and over, thirty years of them: a pickup, and a passenger, and no name for either. The method was never hidden. It was sitting in plain sight the whole time, the way the best hiding places are. You do not smuggle the thing. You put the thing inside the one box in America nobody ever opens -- and you move the box.

There is only the question of where. And for that, there is the phone.

He takes Vern's burner from the drawer -- the dead little thing, the nerve he has not let himself touch. He thumbs it on. It hunts, finds a signal. And after a moment it buzzes, once: not a call. A message. A place, a time, nothing else. The machine does not introduce itself. It simply assumes he is Vern now, because someone has to be.

Marv reads it. Commits it. Deletes it. Now he knows where the road goes tonight.

He draws back the sheet.

We do not linger on the work. We see Marv's face -- the practiced calm, holding -- and his hands, sure and terrible, doing a thing hands like his were never meant to do. A scalpel. A space made. The plastic tucked where grief will never think to look. It is a method for a body nobody is waiting for -- routed, unclaimed, going on to hands that already know what is in it. The ones with a family at the far end will want another way.

He closes the body up with the same care he would give a man's own mother. Then he washes his hands a long time.

EXT. THE STARLITE - PARKING LOT - NIGHT

The last lit windows at the edge of town -- a supper club that has outlived every other place on this stretch, and only barely. Late now: inside, a waitress stacks chairs and a man reaches up to kill the neon. The gravel lot nearly empty. And in it, hazards ticking, a pickup with its hood up and HAL (60s) -- a neighbor, a good and boring man -- bent over a battery that picked a hard cold night to quit on him. His wife MARIE waits in the cab, out of the wind.

The hearse comes down the road, Marv at the wheel, the quiet passenger behind him -- on his way out of town, the first

run, his stomach up around his throat. Hal steps into the headlights and waves him down. Marv's stomach drops. But a man does not roll past a stranded neighbor, and he knows it. He slows.

HAL
Marv? That you? Battery's stone
dead -- sat right through
supper and now she won't turn
over. Any chance you got a
minute for a --

But Hal's eyes have already drifted past him, to the draped shape in the back. The plain curiosity of a small town.

HAL (CONT'D)
...Aw. You're workin'. Who is
it -- anybody I know?

The whole run balanced on the next sentence. And Marv does the thing he was born to do: reaches for a small, true-sounding grief, and hands it across.

MARV
Nobody you'd know, Hal. Fella
from over in Ohio. No people
left to speak of. What family
there is wants him home.

(a mournful half-beat)
Long drive for a quiet
passenger.

Hal nods the way people nod at death -- keen to be done with the subject.

HAL
...Well. That's decent of you.
Haulin' him all that way.

MARV
It's the job.

Marv brings the hearse nose to nose with the truck and runs the cables -- the smuggler and the stranded neighbor, a body ten feet off, small talk about the cold.

While the cables do their work, Hal drifts a step toward the back of the hearse -- just a bored man killing time, the small idle pull of a neighbor's curiosity. His hand comes up

toward the tailgate.

MARV
(easy, not fast -- never
fast)
Best get Marie on home before
she freezes, Hal. How's that
hip of hers holdin' up this
winter?

HAL
Aw, she grouses at it when the
cold sets in -- but the doctor
says she's mendin'. I keep
after her to stay off it, and
you know how much good that
does.

And a man will always turn toward the sound of his own life. Hal is faced full at the cab now, at Marie, and the draped shape in the hearse might as well be a mile behind him. The moment closes, soft as a drawer, and he never knew there was a moment at all.

The truck coughs alive under the cables. Hal's whole face lights.

HAL (CONT'D)
There she is. Marv, I don't
know what we'd have done out
here. You're a good one.

MARV
Get on home, both of you. Give
Marie my best.

Hal waves, grateful, swings up beside Marie, and they roll off toward town. He never learns how close he stood to it.

EXT. STATE HIGHWAY - NIGHT

And Marv turns the other way -- out. Past the town line, where a weathered sign stands in the last of the sodium light: WEIRTON -- GATEWAY TO THE VALLEY. It has said that longer than Marv has been alive.

EXT. STATE LINE - LATER

The hearse holds its lane, unweighed and unwatched, and

crosses the water into Ohio.

I/E. HEARSE - CONTINUOUS

Marv drives. Alone now, the thing done. He waits to feel like a criminal.

It does not come. There was no line to slip, no barrier to beat -- just a dark road, a quiet passenger, a county he has crossed his whole life. Nobody looked. Nothing happened. It was the most ordinary night's work in the world -- and that is the part he cannot get past: not that he got away with something, but that there was never anything to get away from. How little it asked. How easily it went down.

He tells himself it was the once. It is a lie, but an easy one, and it carries him home. He drives on into the dark.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - ARRANGEMENT ROOM - NIGHT

Marv comes in the back, still keyed up from the road. He flips a light -- and stops.

DUTCH is already there -- the stranger from the grave, the one face in this county Marv could not name. Sitting in the good chair, unhurried, a casket catalog open on his knee like a man keeping an appointment. Overcoat folded. Hat on the table beside him. He does not startle. He has been waiting, and he does not mind that he waited.

DUTCH

(turning a page, not looking up)

Mahogany. Vern always tried to talk the families out of the mahogany. Said it was good money going in the ground.

(a small, fond sound)

Sentimental man, though. Underneath. The careful ones usually are.

Marv stands very still. Every instinct he owns for reading a room tells him this is the most dangerous person who has ever stood in it -- and that the danger is precisely the calm.

MARV

We're closed.

DUTCH

I know. That's rather the point
of coming now.

(sets the catalog aside,
finally looks at him)
Sit down, Marv. You've had a
long night. I can smell the
interstate on you.

That lands. Dutch knows about the run. Marv sits, slow,
across from him -- two men in the room where grief is sold.

DUTCH (CONT'D)

Thirty years. I bought that man
his first drink, and near
enough his last. He answered to
me the whole while. Which
means, as of two weeks back, so
do you.

MARV

(carefully)
I don't know what you think I
--

DUTCH

(gently, cutting it off
without heat)
Don't. Please. Not the widow
voice. I have sat through more
funerals than you have buried,
son. I know that voice from the
inside. It's a fine instrument.
Don't play it at me and we'll
get along.

A silence. Marv recalibrates -- this man cannot be charmed.

DUTCH (CONT'D)

You did the run tonight. Clean.
Even talked your way past a
stranded neighbor with a body
in the car -- oh, I had a man
on you for that. First time
out, I like to see how a fellow
carries himself. Vern couldn't
have done it smoother.

(leans in)
You want to know how I'm sure
you'll be fine at this?

And here it happens: Dutch does to Marv the thing Marv does to everyone else.

DUTCH (CONT'D)
I stood at the back of that
man's graveside and watched
them grieve Vern. And I watched
you. You weren't grieving Vern.
You were grieving something
older. And not one soul on that
hill was looking at you. Not
one.

(quiet)
You've spent your whole life in
rooms like that. Being the one
nobody sees.

Marv says nothing. It is the truest thing anyone has said to him in years, and it has come out of the wrong mouth.

DUTCH (CONT'D)
I know that look. I've worn it.
A man that invisible can go
anywhere. Carry anything.
Nobody stops him, because
nobody sees him to stop.

(rising, taking up his
hat)
Loneliest thing in the world.
Or it's a gift. Vern never
could decide which.

At the door, he pauses -- and cracks the one door that will never fully open.

DUTCH (CONT'D)
You've got better hands than he
did. And you're hungrier. Vern
lost his appetite, there at the
end. Started wanting out.
That's what killed him, I
expect.

(mild)
Not the heart. The wanting-out.

MARV

...What's that supposed to mean.

DUTCH

(final, almost kind)
It means we'll talk soon. Lock up, Marv. You never do know who wanders in.

And gone, into the dark. Marv sits alone with the casket catalog and the smell of the road on him. For the first time in his life someone has seen him all the way to the bottom -- and it was the last man on earth he would have chosen to be seen by.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - ARRANGEMENT ROOM - DAY

Not every load leaves the same way. Some Marv drives into the dark himself. This one comes to him -- the other half of the trade, the paying half, exactly as the phone said it would.

The room where a funeral gets planned. Soft chairs, a binder of caskets, a box of tissues set out on the low table. Marv sits across from a MAN (40s) -- THE CLIENT, though he will never give a name. Good coat, bad nerves. He looks at the door, the window, the tissue box -- everything but Marv.

Out of thirty years' reflex, Marv slides the tissues a courteous inch toward him. The Client flinches at it.

MARV

(warm, easy)
Most folks find it helps to start with what they're looking for. Something simple. Something that makes more of a statement.

Code, and they both know it. But the Client is frightened, and frightened men test.

CLIENT

...How do I know you're not wearin' a wire under that funeral suit, Marv.

The room goes very still. Everything rides here. Marv does not bristle. Does not protest -- those are a guilty man's moves. He does the opposite. He goes quieter. Leans in the way he leans toward the bereaved, and lets the Client feel the full warmth of the most trusted man in the county.

MARV

Son. Look at me.

(and the Client does,
helpless)

I have buried this town's
mothers. I have buried its
children, and held the mothers
up while I did it. Thirty
years, every secret this county
ever cried into a chair like
the one you're in -- I kept.
Every one.

(beat)

I don't get it wrong. And I do
not tell. It is the one thing I
have ever been truly good at.

It is a seduction, and it works the way it always works -- because it is ninety percent true. The fear goes out of the Client's shoulders like air from a tire. He believes. They always believe.

CLIENT

(quiet)

...Yeah. Okay.

He reaches into the coat and lays a thick envelope on the table, beside the tissues. Slides it across.

CLIENT (CONT'D)

Half now. Half when it's done.

And here is the hinge of the whole picture. Marv could let it lie. Could say there's been a mistake. Could still, even now, be a man who buries people and does nothing else.

He looks at the envelope a long moment.

Then his hand closes over it. Draws it in. Unhurried.

MARV

(soft, certain -- the

funeral voice, but meant
now)
I'll take good care of him.

The Client nods, relieved, rises, and goes -- a man who was never here, whose name Marv never asked. Because Marv is learning the shape of this now. Learning what not to know.

Alone, Marv sets the envelope in the drawer -- Vern's drawer -- beside the coffee can. And he notices a thing, and we watch him notice it.

His hands are perfectly steady.

FADE OUT.

EXT. RIVER VALLEY ROADS - NIGHT - SERIES OF RUNS

The hearse eats the miles now, sure and unhurried. A montage of a man getting good at a thing he should never have touched:

-- First snow catches him at the Pennsylvania line the first week of December. By Christmas it stands a foot deep on the shoulders, and the runs go on through it, steady as the mail.

-- And one night, on the Ohio route, a state cruiser pulls out of the weigh station dark and settles onto the hearse's bumper. Two miles it rides there. Marv's hands at ten and two, the needle a hair under the limit. Then the light bar comes alive -- and the cruiser swings out and past, away up the valley toward somebody else's trouble. The tail lights shrink and are gone. Marv unlocks his hands from the wheel one finger at a time.

CUT TO:

INT. A TRUCK-STOP DINER - NIGHT

The far end of a run, off the interstate. Vinyl booths gone tacky, a pie case with one slice left, a waitress who stopped listening to anybody years ago. In a back booth Marv sits across from a wary man in a canvas coat -- a MOVER, forties, all forearms and few words. A thermos between them. To the room, two tired men waiting out the weather.

And the talk that passes has two floors. The top floor, for anyone near enough to hear. The basement, for the trade. Marv runs both at once, easy as breathing. The day they put Vern in the ground he could not have managed it. Now it is nothing at all.

THE MOVER

West side's no good tonight.
 Staties are sittin' on the Ohio
 approach, both ends. Everything
 goes east or it don't go.

MARV

(mild -- a professional
 soothing a nervous family)
 Then it goes east.

THE MOVER

East is a state line.

MARV

East is a farm road and a green
 sign, five miles from my back
 door. I carry the paper for it.

The mover doesn't move. So Marv gives him the rest, quiet,
 the way you'd tell a family the casket won't be open.

MARV (CONT'D)

Load goes in before I close
 him.

THE MOVER

And if a scale ever asks?

MARV

Nobody weighs the dead, friend.
 It is the one indecency this
 country still will not stoop
 to.

The mover studies him a moment -- the way you study a card
 player who just did something clean you did not see coming.
 He slides a thick fold under the napkin dispenser.

THE MOVER

(grudging, almost a
 compliment)
 ...Vern used to sit where
 you're sittin'. Good man.
 Always looked like he'd
 swallowed a stone doin' it.

(rising, canvas creaking)
 You look like you're enjoyin'
 yourself.

And he is gone, out into the lot, into a truck with no name on the door. And Marv sits a while with the cold coffee and the fold of bills and a compliment he did not want and cannot answer. He pockets the money and does the one thing he has always done best in all the world: he does not look at it too close. Then he drives home.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - MARV'S OFFICE - DAY

Marv at the desk, the FINAL NOTICE squared in front of him and the checkbook open beside it. The desk phone rings. The bank's number. He picks it up.

MARV
 Coyle and Son.

BEV (V.O.)
 Marv? It's Bev -- over at the
 bank.

MARV
 (warming at once)
 Bev. How've you been keepin'?

BEV (V.O.)
 Oh, upright. Listen -- I'm
 sorry to bother you over there.
 It's the cash deposit. Anything
 over the ten I've got to note
 where it came from, and the
 form won't take "Marv Coyle"
 for an answer.

MARV (CONT'D)
 (no pause at all)
 Preneed. Cash plans going back
 years -- Vern took 'em that way
 and never wrote a receipt in
 his life. I'm still digging out
 from under his filing.

BEV (V.O.)
(relieved)
That'll do it.

MARV (CONT'D)
Send 'em to me if anybody
upstairs wants the contracts.
I'm not hiding anything but
Vern's handwriting.

A pause on the line. Then a small laugh.

BEV (V.O.)
...Marv. Nobody thinks that.

He sets the phone down. And then he writes the check that
clears the bank -- all of it, with room to spare. The pen
moves slow and sure along the line --

And in the drawer, the burner begins to buzz.

Marv's pen does not stop. He finishes the signature to the
last letter of his name. Folds the check into the envelope,
seals it, squares it on the blotter -- the house safe, the
family's whole legacy out of danger, the exact finish line
he set out to reach -- and the phone buzzing against the
wood the whole while.

He sets down the pen. Looks at the sealed envelope a moment.
Then he opens the drawer.

MARV
(into the phone)
...Yeah. I'm here.

He listens. And on the corner of the blotter, beside the
envelope that was supposed to be the end of it, he writes a
time.

He hangs up. He tells himself he will stop, after the next
one. He has been telling himself that a while now.

He catches his reflection in the window glass, and for once
does not reach for the kind face. He just looks. And he
cannot say anymore whether the man looking back is the one
who carried this town's grief for thirty years -- or the one
who has spent all winter keeping his eyes off what his own
two hands are doing.

MARV (CONT'D)

(to no one, quiet)
...One more. Clear one more,
and I'm done.

He does not believe it, even as he says it. That is the true measure of how far in he is -- not that he lies to an empty room, but that he has gotten so good, this winter, at not hearing himself do it.

CUT TO:

INT. A HIGHWAY ROADHOUSE - NIGHT

Not Weirton, and not Steubenville. A dying roadhouse out on the four-lane that stitches the two valleys together -- neutral ground, chosen with care: truckers, drifters, nobody's regulars, a place where a Weirton undertaker and a Steubenville stranger can sit in a back booth and be nothing to anybody. Dutch does not drink where he is known, and he is careful never to be known anywhere that counts. That is why he has lasted.

Two glasses. DUTCH pours from a good bottle he brought himself -- and it is the first time he has poured for Marv as an equal. Marv feels the weight of it settle -- not warmth, quite; more like a hand laid on the back that he understands, dimly, is never going to lift off again.

DUTCH
You cleared your paper. The
bank. I heard.

MARV
...You hear a lot.

DUTCH
It's the whole job, hearing.

(lifts the glass an inch)
You could stop now, you know.
Some men do. Clear the debt,
tidy up, go back to burying the
Methodists. The door's right
there. It's always right there.

And it is not a trick. The debt is cleared. The house is standing. Nothing on this earth requires Marv Coyle to come back next week.

He does not move. He does not reach for his coat.

MARV

(quiet)
...But.

DUTCH

(a small smile)
No but. Just watching which way
a man leans.

(settles back)
You know what Vern's mistake
was, there at the end? Thirty
years, steady as a clock. And
then one day he decided he
wanted to be a good man again.
Late. Right in the thick of it.

(swirls the glass -- and
here, softly, the blade)
His heart went before he ever
got the chance. Kindest thing
it ever did for him.

(easy again, as though it
were nothing)
There's a place across the
water where I sit of an
evening. Back booth, bigger
town. Don't ask for me by name
-- there's nobody in there
who'd know it. Just come in.

He lifts the glass.

DUTCH (CONT'D)

To Vern.

A beat. Marv looks at the man across from him -- the calm,
the patience, the thing that lives underneath. And he
understands every word of what he has just been told: the
door is right there, and no one who reaches for it lives to
walk through.

Marv raises his own glass, level with Dutch's. But he does
not drink from it -- he never has, not once in his life, and
some quiet ballast in him will not start tonight. He holds
it up a moment, and sets it back down, full.

MARV

To Vern.

Dutch notes the untouched glass. He says nothing. But he sees it -- the one small thing this man keeps back -- and files it away, the way he files everything.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - CHAPEL - DAY

A good funeral. A real one. WALT KESSLER, eighty-one, went in his sleep the honest way, and half the county has come to see him off -- a man who fixed their furnaces for fifty years and never once padded a bill. The room is full. The flowers are real -- poinsettias, banked deep around the casket, it being the week of Christmas -- and the grief is real.

And Marv moves through it at the very height of his gift -- a word for the widow, a hand for the grandson, the whole warm machinery of comfort running flawless. This is the thing he was put on earth to do, and he does it better today than he ever has. Nobody in the room has ever seen him more himself.

Nobody in the room knows that in the good mahogany box at the front, tucked into the false lining beneath old Walt's folded hands -- hands Marv set just so, an hour ago, with real and unhurried tenderness -- rides a payload bound east across the Pennsylvania line the moment the last mourner goes home.

He has done both with the same two hands, in the same morning, in the same room. The sacrament and the smuggling, folded into one seamless act of care. It should stop him cold. It does not.

MRS. KESSLER

(clasping his hand at the door, wet-eyed)

Fifty years I had him, Marv. You made him look like the day I married him. I don't know how a man carries this kind of work and stays so gentle.

(a breath, steadier)

We're layin' him down in Burgettstown Sunday. My people are all up there. He always said he didn't mind, long as I was comin' too.

MARV

(and it is true, and it is
a lie, and he can no
longer feel the seam
between them)

It was the honor of my life,
Mrs. Kessler. Walt was one of
the good ones.

She goes. And Marv stands alone a moment with the box, and old Walt in it, and the thing hidden under Walt's hands -- and he closes the lid down over all of it with the same slow reverence he has given ten thousand others. Then he goes to bring the hearse around, for the long drive east, across the line.

FADE OUT.

EXT. A GRAVEL TURNOUT - NIGHT

A nothing place off a county two-lane, where Marv was told to wait with his lights off. He has already done the part of the work nobody sees: the lid raised on the shoulder of an unlit road, old Walt's folded hands lifted aside by the man who arranged them four hours ago, the payload drawn out from under them. Then the hands set back exactly as they were. Walt goes down in Burgettstown Sunday, and no one alive will ever know his hands were moved twice.

And the one who comes up out of the dark for the hand-off is a KID. Nineteen, maybe twenty. Hood up, hands raw and restless, a sniff he cannot stop, eyes that go everywhere and settle nowhere.

The same age, near enough, as the boy Marv will bury in three weeks and does not yet know it.

THE KID

(too fast, too friendly,
needing it to be friendly)
You're the funeral guy. Man,
that's smart, that's real
smart, nobody'd ever -- hey,
you need anybody else? To run
stuff? 'Cause I'm reliable, I
swear, ask anybody, there's
just nothin' out here, man.
There's nothin'.

And for one second the kid is not a link in a chain. He is the very thing Carol will name over her son's casket -- a scared boy in a town with the bottom gone out of it, reaching for the one hand that reached back. Marv could say

a word here. Marv could look at him.

Marv hands him the package, and does not look at him. Keeps his eyes on the dark past the boy's shoulder, his voice flat and closed, and gives him nothing -- no warmth, no face, no mercy. The one thing the whole trade runs on.

MARV
(flat, final)
Go home, son.

He pulls the hearse back onto the road. In the mirror the kid stands alone in the turnout, getting smaller, and then the dark takes him. Marv does not watch him go. He has gotten very good, this winter, at not watching people go.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

This run is different. Marv works over an open casket -- but he is not tucking bricks into a body. He took no drill to it. He walked the display-room row and chose: poplar, no gasket, no seal, a lid that sits on wood and lets the air come and go. Half the boxes in his trade breathe. He has known it thirty years and never once had cause to think of it. He tests the latch with two fingers -- a catch a man could work from the inside -- and sets the lid where it will rest.

The job came down plain: north, this time. Across the real line -- Canada, over the water. A passenger. Marv does not get told who, or why. He has learned not to ask.

EXT. NORTHERN HIGHWAY - NIGHT

Snow, and the great dark of the lake somewhere out past the trees. The hearse runs north. Behind Marv, in the casket, rides something that is not the dead.

A voice. Small. Muffled by the wood. Human -- we never see the face, then or ever.

PASSENGER (O.S.)
...You hear me up there?

Marv does not answer. Eyes on the road, on the coming-down snow.

PASSENGER (O.S.) (CONT'D)

They tell you where I'm goin?
 Nobody'll tell me. That's how
 you know it's real, I guess.
 When nobody'll tell you.

(a breath in the dark)
 Been in this box so long I've
 lost the feelin' in my feet.
 But I keep tellin' myself -- a
 man drivin' this slow, this
 careful, that's a man used to
 carryin' folks gentle. Maybe I
 drew the gentle one.

(filling the dark against
 his own nerves)
 ...This a Cadillac up here? Has
 to be, ridin' this soft. My old
 man had a '76 Coupe DeVille.
 Green as a beer bottle, boat of
 a thing. First car I ever drove
 was that boat -- fourteen years
 old, him white-knuckled beside
 me, hollerin' the whole length
 of the lane.

Marv says nothing. But his eyes flick to the mirror. Some
 old reflex in him -- the one that has never once been able
 to leave a talking soul un-tended -- stirs against his will.

PASSENGER (O.S.) (CONT'D)
 ...You had a first car.
 Everybody's got a first car.
 C'mon. Long road. Give a man
 back here somethin' to hold
 onto.

A long beat. The snow. And then -- because he has never once
 in his life been able to deny a frightened soul the small
 mercy of his voice -- Marv answers. Quiet. Almost against
 himself.

MARV
 ...Sixty-eight Fairlane. Three
 on the tree. Belonged to the
 old man who raised me up in
 this trade. Tires worn down to
 nothin'.

PASSENGER (O.S.)
 (lit up, alive back there)
 There he is. Three on the tree

-- see, that's how a man
learns. Kid today couldn't
drive a stick to save his life.
Lost art. Criminal, is what
that is.

MARV

(and something almost like
a smile finds him)
...Stalled it forty times on
the hill by the church. He
never once raised his voice.
Just said -- again. Every time.
Again.

PASSENGER (O.S.)

Now that's a good man. That's
how you know one -- how he sits
in the passenger seat when it
ain't goin' good.

(warm -- the trap he
doesn't know he's laying)
That's what I'm-a do for my
girl. She's six. Find us some
empty lot when she's big
enough, let her stall it a
hundred times, and not say one
word but again. Teach her on a
stick, like my old man taught
me. Somethin' to hand on down
the line. You know?

And there it is. The road has run, warm mile by warm mile,
straight into the one thing Marv cannot sit in the dark and
hear: a father, folded into a coffin at his back, dreaming
out loud about teaching a six-year-old to drive -- reading
kindness into the smoothness of a ride Marv is being paid to
give. The small smile goes out of him like a match pinched
cold.

MARV

(low -- and the shutters
come down)
...That's enough, now. Long way
yet. Save your strength. Rest
of this road's a quiet one.

The warmth is gone out of his voice. Not cruel. Just shut --
a door drawn quietly to. And the passenger hears it. Of
course he hears it; a man in his position hears everything.

PASSENGER (O.S.)
(smaller)
...Yeah. Sure. Okay.

And for a long while there is only the engine, and the snow, and the dark. Marv thinks it is finished. It is not.

PASSENGER (O.S.) (CONT'D)
(out of the long dark,
quiet now)
...Can I ask you one thing. And
you tell me true. Then I'll
hush, I swear it.

MARV
(after a long moment)
...Ask.

PASSENGER (O.S.)
Are you a good man?

Marv's hands on the wheel. The snow coming down. The question hanging in the cab of a hearse that is carrying a living soul toward a line that was never his to cross.

MARV
(quiet, and it costs him
everything)
...I used to be able to answer
that.

Border lights bloom ahead in the snow -- the real line, at last. The one crossing on this whole route where a man in a uniform can look him in the eye and say no. A booth. An officer. Marv straightens his tie -- the funeral face -- and rolls down to the glass.

Papers. A transit permit and a death certificate -- real ones, filed by Marv's own hand for a real man on a real night. He knows the name on them. He washed that man, and dressed him, and drove him north himself, on a night when the paper and the box agreed. Now he hands him through a window to carry a living one across. Every line of it true. None of it about the man in the box.

OFFICER
(reading, unhurried)
...And this is him.

MARV
 (the funeral face, up and
 running)
 Going home to his people. It's
 a long way. I'd as soon get him
 there before the weather turns.

The officer plays a flashlight over the poplar lid -- and somewhere in that box, a man holds his breath. A long moment. The name on the paper. The box. The undertaker with his hands at ten and two.

Then two fingers lift off a paper coffee cup. Go on. Nobody stops a man carrying the dead -- not even here, where they are paid to. And the hearse rolls across the real line, into Canada and the dark, a living soul riding in a coffin at its back.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - VIEWING ROOM - DAY

A young person in the casket. Nineteen, maybe twenty. Far too young. The room holds the particular devastation of an overdose in a small town -- the thin crowd of the county's shell-shocked young, the parents scooped hollow.

Marv works the room the way he always has: the soft eyes, the steady hand at the elbow. But we know what waits in the cold room. We know what he drove north. We know what fills the drawer.

A MOTHER -- CAROL (fifties, worn thin) -- stands at the casket. She catches Marv's sleeve when he passes and holds it. She needs him, the way this whole town has always needed him.

CAROL
 You did him up so nice, Marv.
 He looks like he's just -- like
 he's sleepin' one off. Like he
 used to on the couch. How do
 you do that? How do you make
 'em look like they're comin'
 back?

MARV
 (automatic now)
 Because part of him is still
 here. In this room. In every
 soul who walked in that door

for him. That's the real work we do today, Carol. We aren't saying goodbye to him. We're teaching ourselves how to carry him.

CAROL

My mother buried her mother with you. My grandmother buried her husband with you. Coyles have been puttin' my family in the ground three generations.

(searching his face)
You're the only one left who does it right. Who cares.

And Marv takes it -- the trust of the woman whose son his own cargo killed -- and carries it like a live coal, and not a flicker of it reaches his face.

MARV

I care about every soul that comes through my door, Carol. That much I can promise you.

She believes him. Of course she believes him. And then something gives way in her -- not anger, something worse: the lost, groping search of a mother for a reason.

CAROL

Then you tell me. You know this town. Know everybody in it, all its business.

He wasn't a bad boy, Marv. He was bored, and he was scared, and there was not one thing left in this town for him to grow up and be. Not since the mill. A scared kid in a place with the bottom gone out of it -- and somethin' came along and filled the hole.

(barely a whisper)
So who does it? Who brings a thing like that into a place like ours -- a place full of people just tryin' to hang on -- and hands it to somebody's baby? What kind of a man?

And there is the question, hung in the air between them. Marv -- who knows the answer, who is the answer, who has the next load boxed in the cold room twenty feet away -- looks this woman in the eye and gives her the only thing he has left to give.

MARV
(softly)
...I wish I knew.

Carol nods, and takes the small comfort of it. Marv gathers her in and holds her while she finally weeps. And over her shoulder, his face -- and for the first time the practiced calm has a hairline crack in it. Something is getting through.

Not enough to make him stop. But enough that he will feel it now. Every single time.

FADE OUT.

EXT. THREE SPRINGS CEMETERY - DAY

And a week later, Marv buries the boy. Carol's boy. The whole thin, gutted town turns out for it -- because in a place like this an overdose is not one family's grief, it is the town's again, the fourth, and every soul at the graveside is quietly doing the math on their own kids.

Marv presides -- which is to say he runs it, the way he runs them all: the pallbearers cued, the family gotten to their feet and kept there, the whole terrible machinery of a burial turning so smooth that the grief has nothing to do but happen. He reads the crowd the way he reads every crowd -- the mother who cannot stand, the father who cannot cry, the boy's friends in their one good shirt apiece, terrified. And he gives each of them exactly what they can carry. The gift, working at the very top of its powers, over a hole in the ground his own cargo helped to dig.

A MINISTER says the words, the same worn words. But it is Marv at the mother's elbow when her knees give way; Marv whose low word to the boy's shaking friends is the thing that finally breaks them open, clean and merciful. Grown men weep into their collars -- and not one of them could tell you it was the undertaker who gave them leave to. The coal he swallowed in the viewing room burns lower in him now, and steadier, and does not go out.

The town leans on him, all of it, the way it always has -- the most necessary man in the county, holding a whole grieving crowd upright, one hand at a time, and never once

seen doing it. The same hand that fed the thing in the box.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - OFFICE - NIGHT

Marv, still in the black suit from the boy's graveside, the tie not yet loosened. The house dark but for the desk lamp. Nobody left to hold up -- and no idea what to do with himself instead.

He opens the ledger. Turns back to an account: KOVACS, WARREN. The balance owing sits at the foot of the column.

He goes to Vern's drawer. Counts it out of the envelopes, used bills, to the dollar, into the canvas bank pouch. Then he takes up the pen and writes across the account, in the thirty-year copperplate: PAID IN FULL.

He sits back. And for the first time all day, his hands are still.

Then he turns the page. And the next. Down the column of the ones who cannot pay.

CUT TO:

INT. A GROCERY - DAY

The town's one real market -- fluorescent, half-stocked, the kind of place where everybody meets everybody eventually. Christmas tinsel still strung over the register, midway through January. It will come down when it falls. RUTH works down a short list. And coming the other way with a hand-basket, off-duty, flannel in place of the uniform, is CODY. They know each other the way everyone here knows everyone: her whole life, his whole life, the same forty streets.

CODY

Miss Ruth.

RUTH

Cody. You tell your mother her ham was the only thing worth eatin' at the church supper. And don't you let the Pruitts hear I said it.

A small, tired smile between them. Then it goes out of both

their faces at once, because there is only one thing this town is really talking about this week.

CODY

(lower)
You were at the boy's service.
Carol's boy.

RUTH

Fourth one, Cody. Fourth. I can remember when the worst thing that happened to a family in this town was the mill movin' a man to second shift.

(shakes her head, quiet
and hard)
Somebody is carryin' that poison into this town, and gettin' rich off it, and sleepin' just fine. I hope I live long enough to hear who.

CODY

(level, though it costs
him)
We're workin' it, Miss Ruth. Harder than folks in this town know. It's a bad business -- keeps us runnin' ragged, most weeks.

And that is every word of it he gives her. Because it is a thing he is working, and Cody does not talk about a thing he is working -- not even here, not even to her. Underneath the level voice, though, it is the exact question that will not quite lie flat in him either. He lets it sit. The hum of the coolers. A few seconds pass.

Then, because it is easier, and because it is the other weight sitting on them both:

CODY (CONT'D)

...You seen much of Marv,
lately?

RUTH

(careful -- something
guarding in her)
...Some. Why.

CODY

I dunno. He's off. Quiet in a way he didn't used to be, tired all the way down. I keep tellin' myself it's just Vern -- losin' Vern hit him hard, and this winter would break anybody. But it's like a light went out somewhere back of his eyes.

Ruth looks at him a long moment. She has watched that light go out of a man before, slow, over forty years -- and she has turned this over more nights than she will admit. But Cody is a good boy with a badge, and whatever this is, she will not be the one to set it in his hands. Not until she understands it herself.

RUTH

(gently, closing the door)
He buried his oldest friend with his own two hands this winter, Cody. Grief doesn't keep a schedule. Give the man some room.

CODY

(nods, letting it go -- for now)
...Yeah. 'Course. You're right.

(softer -- the badge set down a moment)
...Good to see you out and about, Miss Ruth. Don't go workin' that list too hard.

RUTH

(the dry warmth back in her)
Go on, get. And you tell your mother I'll trade her my chowder for that ham of hers -- fair's fair.

CODY

(a real smile now)
She'll never in her life do it. But I'll tell her.

And they part at the end of the aisle -- the deputy and the widow, the two people left alive who love Marv Coyle best -- having circled the truth of him together for the length of a grocery run, and brushed it, and set it back down, and walked away.

FADE OUT.

INT. SHERIFF'S STATION - BULLPEN - NIGHT

Late. Most of the desks dark. CODY at his -- a county map pinned above it, a row of case folders fanned out under the lamp. The overdoses: four of them, and a fifth folder still empty with a name already typed on the tab. He is not supposed to be working this. It is a state matter, everyone keeps telling him. He works it anyway.

A highway map. A red pen. He marks where each of them turned up. He marks the two dealers the state boys rolled up last spring -- both small, both dry now, and still the stuff keeps coming. He sits back and looks at the mess of red and does not like the shape of it.

A tired older deputy -- HOLLIS (50s) -- drifts past with a coffee, sees the map, and sighs like a man who has watched younger men break their hearts on this exact wall before.

HOLLIS

You're gonna give yourself an ulcer, kid.

CODY

(not looking up)
It's comin' from somewhere.
Movin' some way. Stuff doesn't just fall out of the sky onto a nineteen-year-old.

HOLLIS

'Course it's movin'. Question's whose problem it is when it does. Turns up in our county, that's us. Turns up across the bridge -- that's Jefferson County, Ohio, and good luck to you. Comes up out of Pennsylvania, whole other state again.

(taps the map, three

places at once)
 Son, we are the one town in
 America a man can stand in and
 spit into three jurisdictions.
 Anybody ever wanted to move a
 thing through here, they picked
 the one spot on the map where
 nobody owns the road it's
 ridin' on.

He wanders off. Cody sits with it. And his eye drifts --
 idle, unwilling -- to a scrap in his own hand, clipped to
 nothing at the edge of the desk: PETRAK - hearse - Ohio rd -
 2am?

He looks at it a long moment. Then takes it down, folds it,
 puts it in his shirt pocket. Tells himself it's nothing.
 Tells himself he'll ask, just to put the old man's mind at
 rest. He turns off the lamp.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - OFFICE - DAY

CODY

Hey, Marv. Brought you the
 paper on the Tillman boy.
 Coroner signed off this
 mornin'. Opioid overdose. Same
 as the rest.

MARV

(gentle)
 How many's that now, son.

CODY

(quiet)
 ...Five. He's the fifth this
 winter. Nineteen years old. I
 went to school with his sister.

(rubs his face)
 Now I'm hand-deliverin' his
 death certificate over here
 like it's a phone bill. State
 boys keep sayin' the stuff's
 comin' up through the valley by
 the truckload, and they can't
 find the pipe. And meantime
 we're buryin' the whole junior
 class.

A silence. Marv -- who knows exactly how it moves -- puts a hand on the boy's shoulder. The real comfort and the lie of it, both at once.

MARV

You're doin' right by 'em,
Cody. That's all any of us can
do. See 'em decent into the
ground.

Cody nods, grateful. Then, almost an afterthought -- sheepish:

CODY

Oh -- hey. Can I ask you
somethin, and it's probably
nothin. Feel dumb even bringin'
it up.

MARV

Always.

CODY

Old man Petrak swears he saw
your hearse out on the Ohio
road a couple nights back. Two,
three in the mornin'. I told
him he was seein' things. But
you know how he is -- wouldn't
let it go till I asked. So. I'm
askin'.

And there it is -- the one thing this whole operation cannot survive: someone looking. In the hands of a boy who does not even know he is holding it. Marv reaches for the excuse that worked on Hal, and hands it over warm.

MARV

(easy)

...Oh, that'd have been me,
sure. Petrak's not seein'
things -- tell him his eyes are
fine. A transfer, is all: fella
from over in Ohio, no people
left but a sister out east who
wanted him brought home. Middle
of the night's the only time
the road's clear.

(a small rueful smile)
Long drive for a quiet
passenger. Paper's in the file,
if Petrak wants it -- tell him
I'll run him a copy.

CODY
See, that's what I figured.
Told him you don't go haulin'
bodies around for the fun of
it.

He laughs. Marv laughs. Then Cody sobers, and the real
reason he lingered comes out.

CODY (CONT'D)
...You've seemed a long way off
lately, Marv. Ever since Vern.
You're about all I got left
that still feels like home. So.
Just checkin' the home's still
standin'.

And Marv -- the man who could end all of it with one true
word to the deputy in front of him -- smiles the warm smile,
and lies with his whole body.

MARV
Home's still standin', son. Go
on. Go be the law.

Cody goes, reassured. Marv watches the patrol car pull out,
and for a moment cannot remember the last true thing he said
to that boy.

CUT TO:

EXT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PARKING LOT - NIGHT

Marv comes out to the hearse in the back lot, where the
pavement gives out at the old Panhandle rail bed -- the
rails pulled up years ago, just a dark cut running off along
Harmon's Creek and out of town. A man is leaning on the
hearse, and does not move off when Marv approaches. DEKE
(35) -- lean, hungry, a jailhouse stillness to him.

DEKE
Marv Coyle. The undertaker.

Marv turns. He cannot place the man -- and in a town this size, in thirty years, that has never once happened. That alone is a wrong note, sounding low.

MARV

(even)
...Do I know you?

DEKE

No. But I've known about you a while.

(looks him over,
unimpressed)
That route was Vern's. Thirty years. And the man across the river spent the last two of 'em tellin' me it'd come to me when the old man was done. 'Soon, Deke. Patience, Deke.' Danglin' it like a set of keys.

(harder)
Then Vern goes in the ground -- and it goes to the fella who paints the faces on corpses. Not so much as a word to me.

(a look up at the dark building)
You got your name on a building. I got a truck that don't start in the cold. You was born under yours. I aim to hang mine.

MARV

(reaching for the voice -- warm, disarming)
Whatever it is you were promised, that's no doing of mine. I'm sure we can --

DEKE

(flat, cutting straight through it)
Don't. Don't do the voice.

(steps in)
I've had my eye on this town a good while, Marv. On Vern. On

you. Doesn't work on me. 'Cause
I've watched long enough to see
what's under it. Nothin'.
There's nothin' under it.

(almost admiring, which is
worse)
You're a soft man in a hard
business, Marv. And soft things
break. I'm just gonna be
standin' right here when you
do.

He pushes off the hearse, unhurried, and goes -- down off
the lot and along the old rail line, swallowed by the dark
cut where the trains used to run.

Marv stands alone in the empty lot. For the first time in
his life, the voice failed him.

Then he goes inside -- to Vern's desk, to the drawer -- and
comes back out with the burner in his hand. One number in
it. No name. He dials, and looks off down the dead rail bed
while it rings.

It rings. And rings. And somewhere in there, before anybody
picks up, Marv takes the phone away from his ear and ends
it.

He puts the phone away and stands a moment where Deke stood,
looking down the dark cut the man went into.

FADE OUT.

INT. RUTH'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Ruth takes his coat from him before he has finished deciding
whether to stay. She is the one who buried a husband, and
yet here she is, fussing over Marv, because that is the
thing these two have always done: taken turns being the one
who carries the other.

RUTH
Sit. You're too thin. Always
were. Even as a boy -- your
father used to swear you'd blow
away in a strong wind, and then
who'd be left to bury us all.

MARV
(a rare, real smile)
...He did say that. I'd

forgotten he said that.

RUTH

Course you did. You were too busy trailin' him 'round that prep room like a duckling, beggin' to be let hold the good comb. Eight years old, in a little black suit he had cut down to your size.

(she sets the cup in front of him)

I held your hand at his funeral, Marv. You didn't cry. Whole town said, what a brave little man. I knew better. You were already learnin' to do the face -- to carry the whole room, so nobody'd ever have to carry you.

Marv sits with that.

MARV

(quiet, deflecting toward why he came)

...I came to tell you we're square, you and me. Warren's funeral. It's taken care of. Consider it thirty years of your family's kindness to mine.

And the warmth in Ruth's face goes still. She is not a woman who mistakes a gift for a kindness.

RUTH

...The whole thing? Marv, that's thousands.

MARV

It's done.

RUTH

Where's a man whose place was three months off the bank come into money enough to wave off a funeral like a cup of coffee.

MARV
(the warmth, deploying)
Ruth --

RUTH
(quiet, and it stops him
cold)
Don't. Not that -- not with me.
I knew you before you ever
learned how to do that to
people.

(she looks at him like she
can see it on his skin)
I'm not gonna ask what's got
hold of you. I'm too old to
want the answer. But somethin'
has. And I can see it plain as
a bruise.

MARV
(the old reflex, reaching
for it)
...It's nothin', Ruth. You've
got yourself worked up over a
hard winter, is all --

And there the voice fails him. Not with her. The one
instrument that has never once let him down, gone useless in
the single kitchen it was never any good in. He cannot
finish the lie, and he has nothing true to set in its place.

He looks at the coffee he has not touched. At the woman who
held his hand when he was eight, holding it still, the only
way she has left. Then he does the one thing the voice
cannot do for him: he rises, and goes.

FADE OUT.

INT. THE OLD LODGE BAR - LATE AFTERNOON

The low afternoon sun makes the near-dead tavern sadder than
the dark ever does. The door opens and MARV steps in -- a
funeral director in a drinking man's bar in the middle of
the afternoon, its own kind of sight. The old BARMAN (70s)
looks up and knows him, as the whole town knows him.

BARMAN
Well. Marv Coyle. Either
somebody died in here and I
missed it, or the world's

finally endin'.

MARV
(easing onto a stool)
Diet Coke, if you got it, Sam.

BARMAN
(mock-disgusted, already
reaching for the soda gun)
Thirty years I been tryin' to
sell you a real drink. Man
don't drink, don't smoke, don't
gamble -- I can't make one thin
dime off you. You're bad for
business, Coyle, you know that?

MARV
(the ghost of a smile)
So I've been told.

The barman sets the glass down. Marv turns it in his hands
and does not so much as sip it. He is not here for the Coke.

BARMAN
So. You didn't put on the good
coat to come drink soda pop
with me. Somethin's on your
mind.

MARV
(a beat -- easing toward
it)
This was Vern's place. Back
when. Wasn't it.

BARMAN
(softening, the memory
coming up)
Vern. Sure. Remember him
longer'n I remember most. Sat
right there on that stool,
forty years.

MARV
...How was he. At the end --
this past year or so.

BARMAN

Funny you should ask. Changed, those last few months. Used to be, Vern closed this place down every night. But he took to comin' in alone. Wouldn't drink. Wouldn't talk. Just sat right there, starin' at the wall.

(shrugs)

Like a man waitin' on a bus he already knew wasn't comin'.

Marv nods, slow. That is the Vern he found on the prep-room floor -- a man who had already left, months before his heart made it official.

MARV

He ever tell you what it was?
What changed him?

BARMAN

(shakes his head)

Vern? Naw. Forty years, and I don't believe I ever knew that man one inch beneath the surface. Kept his own counsel. Whatever was eatin' at him, he carried it down into the ground with him.

And there it is. The man who knew Vern longer than anyone left alive never truly knew him at all. Whatever began it, whatever ended it, lives in one place only now -- with the man who was there.

Marv stands. Leaves the soda untouched on the bar. Sets down a bill anyway.

MARV

I gotta run, Sam. Got somethin'
I need to take care of.

BARMAN

(a small nod, no idea)
You always do, don't you.

The line the whole town would say about Marv Coyle -- dependable, always seeing to things. Only tonight, what he is seeing to is the man who buried Vern alive thirty years

before his heart ever stopped.

CUT TO:

INT. DUTCH'S BOOTH - EARLY EVENING

Across the river, in the bigger town -- where nobody knows Marv Coyle, and nobody much knows Dutch either, which is exactly how Dutch has always kept it. The place he named, and Marv never thought he would use. Dutch sits alone in the back, unhurried over a drink. He looks up, not surprised -- Dutch is never surprised -- as Marv sits down across from him, uninvited, a new hardness in him.

MARV

(the hard new edge)
How'd you two meet. You and Vern. In the beginning.

DUTCH

(mild -- he does not mind telling it)
The way these things always begin. A kindness a man never learns the price of. He was thirty-odd -- broke, scared, drinking alone on a weeknight. I bought him a beer. I never saw a man so grateful in all my life.

MARV

(quiet -- it lands)
...The Old Lodge. Over in Weirton. That's where you did it.

DUTCH

(a small nod)
Is that the name of it. I only went the once. Thirty years I had no cause to go back -- till your Vern died on me, and left the whole thing to a stranger. You don't set foot in a town like that, not once a thing's been done right in it. Not unless it drags you.

MARV

(and here it costs him)
Funny thing. I just came from
there. Sat on his stool. Sam's
still behind that bar -- forty
years he's poured there. He
watched you hand Vern the rope,
and never knew to this day that
he saw a single thing.

DUTCH

(almost tender)
That's the whole trick of it.
You don't take a man. You wait
till he's going under, and you
hand him the rope -- and he
thanks you, and never once
feels the anchor tied to the
other end. Vern thanked me for
thirty years.

MARV

He wanted out, at the end. You
said so yourself. And then his
heart just -- stopped. Awful
convenient.

Dutch does not rise to it. He looks at Marv the way a man
looks at weather coming in.

DUTCH

(unhurried)
You came a long way to say
that. Over the water, onto my
side of it. Thirty years, Marv,
and Vern never once did that --
came out to me, on my ground.
He understood a thing you
haven't yet. Whose ground he
was standing on.

And Marv feels it then: the two men at the dark end of the
room who have not once looked at him and have not once
stopped watching. Over here he is not the most trusted man
in the county. Over here he is a stranger nobody would miss,
on ground he does not own. He pushes the fear down and asks
it anyway.

MARV

(the hardest thing he has

ever said)
...Did you kill Vern.

A long silence. And Dutch's glass stops turning in his hand. A full second. Then it goes on turning, and the calm closes over whatever that was like water. And Dutch does not answer the question. He answers the man.

DUTCH
(almost gentle)
No. You don't want to ask me
that. You only think you do.

(leans in)
You didn't drive across a river
in the dark to find out what
happened to Vern. You came to
find out what happens to you.
When the wanting turns a man
soft. When he starts looking
for the door. That's the
question under your question,
Marv -- you just haven't got
the nerve to ask it plain.

It goes in clean, because it is true. To be read to the bone
by this man is its own kind of dying. Marv says nothing. He
cannot.

DUTCH
(sitting back -- and now
an awful generosity)
But you asked about Vern. So.
You want it -- the whole of it?
What Vern was to me, what I was
to him, right down to the last
kindness I ever did the man?
Sit back down. I'll give you
every word.

(quiet)
Only understand what it costs
you. A man who hears a thing
like that is a man who's in it
to his teeth. No road back. No
daylight left. You'll be
standing exactly where Vern
stood.

There it is: the one answer Marv crossed the river for, held
open like a door -- and the drop on the far side of it. To
hear it is to belong to Dutch all the way, to be Vern, to
have no way back up. Marv is halfway to his feet before he

knows he has decided.

MARV
(barely)
...No.

DUTCH
(not surprised -- Dutch is
never surprised)
No. I didn't think so.

Marv goes. And behind him -- where Marv does not turn to see it -- Dutch sets down the glass he has been turning all night, and does not pick it up again.

He came for the truth about the one death that matters to him, and he leaves having refused it -- because the not-knowing is the last thin thing standing between him and being all the way in. The man who reads every corpse in the county chose, tonight, not to read this one. He will carry that cowardice, and that mercy, to his own grave.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

A night or two on from the river. Marv works late over a body on the table -- the ordinary version of the job, the honest kind, the kind that once was the whole of it. He does not hear the back door. He does not hear anything, until:

DEKE (O.S.)
Long hours. For an honest man.

Marv turns. DEKE is inside -- in the prep room, Marv's one sanctum, drifting the steel tables, trailing a finger down the tray of instruments like a man browsing a shop he means to own. Nothing lazy in him tonight. He has something, and he knows it.

DEKE (CONT'D)
Followed you out to the state
line. Couple nights back, two
in the mornin'. A hearse, no
funeral on the books, rollin'
over into Ohio.

(lifts a scalpel, turns it
to the light, sets it down
out of place)

Now -- I didn't get a picture.
Didn't get the count, didn't
get a name. Your little
operation's got that much goin'
for it. Only works long as
nobody's lookin'.

(smiles)
But I'm lookin'. And I know one
eager young deputy who'd start
lookin' too, he ever got the
whisper.

Marv sets down his own instrument, slow. And he reaches --
out of thirty years of instinct -- for the voice. The
warmth. The thing that has never once failed him with a
frightened man or an angry one.

MARV
(warm, reasonable)
Whatever you think you saw out
there, I expect there's an
easier road through it than the
one you're on. Sit down. Let
you and me talk it out like
grown --

DEKE
(not even annoyed -- he
just watches it slide off)
There it is. The voice.

(steps in close)
Told you once already. Save it.
I sat in the back pew of this
town my whole life and watched
you pour that syrup over every
grievin' widow in three
counties. Don't reach me. Never
did.

The one weapon Marv owns, spent and useless, in front of the
one man it was never going to move. Marv goes still. And
Deke, close now, sets the knife where he already knows it
lives.

DEKE (CONT'D)
I put in the time. The dirt.
And instead they hand it to the
powder-and-rouge man -- paints
the dead, smiles at the livin',
never once had the stomach for

the real work.

(soft)
You ain't half the man Vern
was. And even Vern -- they used
him up and dropped him in a
hole. What do you figure they
do with you, when you stop
bein' useful?

It lands on every bruise Marv owns -- the invisibility,
Vern's shadow, the fear he will not say out loud. Stripped
of the voice, stripped of the ground beneath him, Marv has
nothing left to reach for but the plain, bare question.

MARV
(quiet)
...What do you want.

DEKE
(the grin coming back)
In. Vern's route, my cut of it,
right off the top. Or I put
that flea in your boy Cody's
ear and stand back and watch
this quiet little place come
down around you.

Marv says nothing. And maybe it is the silence, or maybe it
is the room -- but something in Deke keeps talking.

DEKE (CONT'D)
(quieter -- the swagger
thinning, just for a
moment)
There's a garage sits empty out
the Moundsville road. Been
empty six years. Bank'd let it
go for next to nothin'.

(off Marv's look)
What -- you figure a man like
me wants this? Ridin' powder
for a cut of a cut? Three good
years and I buy that place
outright.

Then the grin comes down over it again, like a shutter.

He crosses to go. At the door, almost gentle:

DEKE (CONT'D)

Think it over. You got till I
get bored.

And gone. Marv stands alone in the fluorescent hum, the
honest body still open on the table behind him.

Then he crosses to Vern's desk -- to the drawer he has never
quite closed -- and lifts out the burner. One number in it.
No name. The single number that is the whole reason a man
keeps a phone like this at all. He thumbs it awake, dials,
and waits, and when it connects he does not have to ask who
is on the other end.

MARV

(flat, careful)
...It's Coyle. We got a
problem. I need to see you.

He listens a moment. Then sets the phone down.

CUT TO:

INT. DUTCH'S BOOTH - NIGHT

Dutch is waiting when Marv comes across the water -- Marv
made the call, and Dutch named the place, the way he names
everything. Two glasses again, Dutch's habit. Marv sits. He
is not rattled. He made the call from a still, cold place,
and he has carried the stillness here with him.

MARV

There's a man been following
me. Out to the line, two nights
back. Wants Vern's route -- a
cut of it. Says if he doesn't
get it, he goes and has a
conversation with the sheriff's
department.

DUTCH

(unsurprised, turning his
glass)
Deke Whatley. Moundsville. In
and out of Northern Regional
since he was a boy.

(mild)

I know who he is, Marv. I know
who most everybody is.

MARV

Then you know he's a problem.

DUTCH

I know he's a loud man in a trade that runs on quiet. That's a thing, yes. You, now -- you moved my northbound freight and never once asked what it was. Quality like that I don't hand to the Dekes of this world.

A silence. Dutch lets it sit -- the way a patient man lets a thing sit, until the other man is the one who reaches for it.

DUTCH (CONT'D)

You could pay him. A cut buys men like that a season of peace, maybe two. You could try to scare him, though I don't believe that's in your bag. You could go to your deputy first, get out ahead of it. Half a dozen quiet roads through a man like Deke Whatley.

(looks at him)

And yet here you sit. Across a river, at my table, at this hour. So we can leave the half a dozen to one side. Can't we.

The thing hangs in the air, unspoken and enormous. And Marv -- who has spent a life making the unbearable sound gentle -- reaches for the gentlest possible shape of it.

MARV

...I just came for advice. How a man handles a thing like this.

DUTCH

(almost tender -- the worst thing about him)
That's the funeral voice, son. You're using it on yourself now. You didn't come for

advice. You came because you want it to stop, and you want the hands to be somebody else's. That's a decision, Marv. You've only trained yourself so well you can't hear your own voice make it.

Marv says nothing. There is nothing to say that would be both true and bearable.

DUTCH (CONT'D)
(settles back, the matter closed)
It's all right. That's what I'm for. Leave Mr. Whatley to me.

(a small, final nod)
Go on home. Sleep. The hard part's already behind you, Marv -- it was the phone call.

Marv rises, and goes. And the thing he feels, stepping out into the cold, is not horror. He waits for it -- the way he once waited to feel like a criminal out on the road that first night. It does not come.

What comes instead is relief.

CUT TO:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

Dutch has drawn the three of them together under a pretext -- a sit-down, a deal to be struck. Steel tables. The drains. The smell of the work. Deke leans on a gurney like he owns it already. And Marv stands apart by the instrument tray, and he knows -- because he made the call -- exactly what this room is for tonight. He has decided to say nothing. He is holding to that decision the way a man holds his breath underwater.

Dutch is the very picture of reason, a ledger-mind laying out terms.

DUTCH
We're here to settle a thing,
the three of us. Say it plain,
settle it, and it's done.

(to Deke)

You've been wanting Vern's ground. The north end. What was his.

DEKE
(greed rising -- surprised
it's come so easy)
...Damn right I do. The ground
you told me was comin' to me.
Two years of 'soon, Deke.
Patience, Deke.' Well -- the
old man's in the ground now. So
it's mine.

DUTCH
(mild -- waving it off
like smoke)
I said soon, Deke. I never said
when. A man shouldn't go
building a house on another
man's 'soon.'

(the pivot, easy as
arithmetic)
So here's what's real. Nobody
carries all of it -- not even
our friend there at the table.

(a nod at Marv)
You'd run the south end.
Marshall, Wetzel, on down the
river. Marv keeps the north.
You hold your own product, you
take your own count. Fifteen
off the top comes up to me.

DEKE
(pushing now, emboldened)
Twenty stays with me. I know
that road better'n the
powder-man ever will.

DUTCH
(mild, allowing it --
letting him win)
Eighteen. And you learn to
knock before you walk into a
man's place of business.

And there it is -- the thing that damns him. Deke thinks he
is winning. The tension goes out of his shoulders. He is

being haggled with, man to man, and to a man like Deke, haggling means respect. He grins.

DEKE

(to Marv now, almost
friendly, the swagger all
the way back)
See, undertaker? This is how
it's done. No hard feelings.
You and me, we're gonna do just
fine, you'll --

And he turns to Marv -- for the thing a man reaches for when he thinks he has won: a witness to it. For one held breath, the two of them look at each other. Marv knows what is coming. Deke does not. One word. One look held a beat too long, and Deke might read the room, might bolt.

And the word is in him. His lips part. His hand comes up off the tray -- toward what, he will never afterward be able to say.

Then the breath goes out of him unspent, and Marv looks away. The hand settles on an instrument that did not need straightening, and he straightens it. The old gesture -- the lily, the sheet drawn over Vern. And with that small turning-away, Marv lets a man die.

Dutch, still seated, still easy, lets one hand drift inside his coat -- unhurried, the way another man reaches for his cigarettes. And he keeps talking, in the same voice he used on mahogany.

DUTCH

Your trouble was never
ambition, Deke. Ambition I can
use. But our friend at the
table -- he's got the rarer
gift, the one Vern had. Worth
more to me than ambition ever
was.

(the hand comes back out
of the coat, and there is
no hurry in it at all)
Your trouble is the one thing
this whole trade runs on. The
one thing you were never going
to learn --

DEKE

(the grin going, half a

second too late)
...the hell are you --

A sound -- small, flat, and final. Deke stops. Looks down at himself, puzzled, almost polite about it. Then folds to the floor between the two steel tables. One more body come to rest in the room where bodies come to rest.

DUTCH
-- patience.

Silence, but for the fluorescent hum. Marv has not moved. He said nothing, and the body is on his floor now, and it will be his two hands that put it in the ground.

Dutch pockets it. He gets up out of the chair the way a man his age gets up out of a chair -- a hand on the arm of it, taking his time. Turns to Marv, and his voice is kind -- which is the very worst part of it.

DUTCH (CONT'D)
Now. We see to him. That's your trade, isn't it -- quiet departures. No name. No stone. Just gone. You've done it a thousand times. And don't tell me where. A thing only one man knows stays known by one man.

(beat)
Only difference tonight is who's watching. And nobody's watching, Marv. Nobody ever is.

Dutch lifts his coat from the chair, unhurried, and goes out into the night. To him the matter is already closed, already behind him.

And Marv is left alone with the body between the two steel tables. And then he does the only thing his hands have ever known to do with the dead: he begins to tend it. Reaches to fold Deke's hands across his chest. To straighten the collar. To set the face at rest -- the small, holy work he has given ten thousand strangers.

He catches himself. Looks down at his own hands as though they belong to some other man. This one gets none of it. Not the folded hands. Not the smoothed collar. Not one soft word. Marv draws his hands back.

Then, in silence, he does the other thing thirty years have taught him -- the professional thing, the thing that makes him so much better at this than any amateur with a shovel.

The pockets first: emptied into a manila envelope, itemized by habit, the way the trade has emptied ten thousand pockets -- the hands doing the work so the man does not have to look. The envelope goes in the drawer where the unclaimed effects of the county's dead wait out their years. Then he boxes what must not be found. A plain casket, no plate, no flowers. The lid drawn down. Just a box, and a man inside it the world has already agreed not to look for.

Then the room. He has scrubbed this floor ten thousand times. Never once for this.

CUT TO:

EXT. AN OLD FARM CEMETERY - NIGHT

Snow, and the frozen dark, high on a county back-slope where a dozen sunk and nameless stones lean in the weeds -- one of the old farm burying grounds scattered across these hills, untended fifty years, the kind of forgotten ground only an undertaker still keeps a map of.

Marv works the frozen ground the only way one man works it -- the pick before the shovel, the crust coming off in plates. It takes him the better part of the night. Twice he stops and stands in the hole with his breath going white and his hands past feeling, and twice he starts again, because the other choice is a body in his prep room at daylight.

Then he lowers the plain casket into earth he chose for the one reason that matters: no living soul will ever have cause to come here. His trade makes even this look ordinary. A box. A hole of the right depth. A man who knows precisely how deep.

He fills it in. In silence. The rite that would come for any other soul on earth never comes at all. And something of his own goes down into the dark with the box, and does not come back up.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - FRONT HALL - DAY

The bell over the door. And here is CODY again -- shouldering in backward out of the cold, two coffees balanced in one hand, cap in the other. Same as ever.

CODY

Hey, Marv. Brought you a real coffee. Not that gas-station

tar you keep behind the desk.

He sets one on the counter. Marv takes it. He looks like a man who has not slept -- because he has not. Cody clocks it, the way you clock a friend, not a suspect.

MARV

Mornin', Cody. How're you keepin'?

CODY

You look rougher'n half the folks you work on, you know that? This winter's got the whole county low -- coldest anybody can remember, river froze near to the middle. Mom says you're not eatin'. She's makin' noises about startin' up the casseroles again -- so consider yourself warned.

MARV

(the warm face, up and running)
Tell your mother I'm fine. And that I'd never once say no to the chicken thing.

CODY

(grinning)
She'll have it on your step by Sunday. You just doomed yourself, you know that.

The old, easy rhythm, the one true thing left in Marv's week. And then Cody's face does the thing it does when the job climbs up over the friendship. He turns the cap in his hands. Doesn't quite find Marv's eye.

CODY (CONT'D)

...Listen. You know a fella name of Deke Whatley? Small-time. In and out of Moundsville his whole life.

MARV

(a small frown, like he is searching for it)

Whatley... Don't think so.
Should I?

CODY

Nah. No reason you would.
Small-time nobody. But truck's
been sittin' outside the Legion
three days runnin', and ain't a
soul laid eyes on him since.

(a cop's shrug he doesn't
quite feel)
Probably skipped out on
somebody. Guys like that do.
But it got flagged, so I gotta
ask it around. You hear
anything, you'd let me know?

Marv -- standing not two miles from where he put the man in
the ground three nights back -- gives his boy the warm, and
lies clean.

MARV

'Course I would, son.

And that is that. Cody believes him. Of course he does -- it
is Marv.

CODY

(pulling his cap back on,
halfway to the door
already)
'Preciate it. Anyhow -- might
get quieter around here before
long. State boys are finally
makin' the smart play: gonna
sit on the river crossings,
startin' weekend after next.
Both bridges. Don't go
spreadin' that around.

(a grin, at the door)
Drink that coffee while it's
hot, would you -- I didn't haul
it clear across town to watch
you let it go cold. Sunday.
Casserole. That's twice now you
been warned.

The bell over the door, and he is gone.

And in the quiet, the thing settles on Marv that would not

settle while Cody stood there being kind. Cody has a name now. A flagged report. A reason to go looking. And every last thread the boy might pull -- the hearse out on the state road, the funeral that never was, old Petrak watching from his window -- runs back through this building. Back to Marv.

He looks at the coffee steaming on the counter. At the door to the prep room. His deadliest danger and his last cover, wearing the same young, trusting face.

Then he crosses into the dark of the prep room, and the burner is in his hand, and it is done before he has let himself think about it.

MARV
(into the phone, low)
...It's Coyle. They mean to sit
on the crossings, weekend after
next. Both bridges.

He listens.

MARV (CONT'D)
...No. Just that.

He sets the phone down on the steel table. Don't go spreadin' that around.

In the front room, the coffee Cody carried across town for him is still warm.

CUT TO:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

Marv alone, in the room where he once practiced the kind face. And now he goes looking -- deliberately -- for the horror he knows a man is supposed to feel.

He looks at his hands. Steady. He waits for the guilt to climb up out of him.

It does not come. Not enough. And what he finds underneath instead is the thing he could never say to a living soul: nothing. A great numb quiet where the horror should be, a stillness that has been spreading in him all winter. He has simply stopped being able to feel the edges of what he does.

But their voices are in the room with him. Cody: all I got left that feels like home. Ruth: plain as a bruise. If he

keeps on, he takes them down too -- and the last two threads to the man he used to be.

And then the thought comes -- uninvited, enormous, the first time it has ever come at all: that there should be a way out of this. Not how a man takes it. Only that it is there, somewhere, past the glass.

Marv looks at his own face in the dark window, the face no one has ever once seen through -- and for a held breath his eyes go past it, hunting the shape of a door. His glance flicks to the back door. To Vern's drawer. To the dark beyond the both of them.

Then he looks away. Not yet. He will not follow the thought all the way to its end -- to the thing he already half-knows and cannot yet hold: that Dutch lets no one leave, and that Vern is the proof of it. He shuts it down before it can finish forming. But it does not go. It will not go now.

FADE OUT.

INT. RUTH'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Ruth sets a coffee down for him she did not ask if he wanted -- and beside it, an envelope, thick with cash. She slides it across.

RUTH

That's for the funeral. All of it. I'll not have it waved off.

MARV

Ruth. I forgave that months ago. Let me have done one kind thing this winter and not take it back.

RUTH

That's just the thing. A man with nothin' to spare doesn't go forgivin' bills. And a man who's got plenty all of a sudden -- deep in the worst winter this town's seen in years -- I've lived long enough to know the shape of where that comes from.

(she does not touch her own coffee)

A man drownin' doesn't hand out
life rafts, Marv. Not unless
he's found himself somethin' to
stay afloat on. And I don't
believe I want to know what.

Marv looks at the envelope. And for the first time in his
life, in the one kitchen where he has never once had to run
the face, the thing rises up and wants out of him.

MARV
(quiet, feeling for the
edge of it)
...You carry people your whole
life, Ruth. Everybody's worst
day, you're the one holds it
steady. And not once, in fifty
years, does a soul think to ask
who's holdin' you up.

(a breath)
And then somebody finally does.
Looks right at you. Needs you.
And God help me -- it felt like
gettin' warm. Like I'd been
cold my whole life and never
once knew there was supposed to
be a fire.

RUTH
(very still)
And what's it cost you. Gettin'
warm.

And there it is -- the door, held open a crack. She has
walked him all the way to the edge of saying it. And Marv
looks at the one soul on earth he could tell -- and cannot.
The face comes down even here. Even now.

MARV
(barely)
...I can't.

RUTH
No. I don't suppose you can.

(quieter -- the
Vern-mirror)
I watched the lights go out
behind Vern's eyes over forty
years, and never once knew what

did it. You're doin' it to
yourself in a single winter.
Whatever it's worth, Marv -- it
isn't.

She rises. Done.

RUTH (CONT'D)
I buried my husband. I knew
your daddy. I knew you when you
were a boy who cried at his own
dog's funeral. Whoever's
wearin' your face these days --
I don't shake his hand.

And she turns her back on him, and busies her hands at the sink -- the widow's ritual, the conversation over. The one person whose good opinion Marv has lived his whole life to keep will no longer look at him. The one person who ever truly saw him has closed her eyes to him for good -- and the only eyes left that find him now are the wrong ones.

Marv stands a moment in the ruin of it. Then he sets his hat on his head, and goes.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - MARV'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Marv comes in from the cold with Ruth's turned back still on him, and does not reach for the light. Vern's papers lie where he left them, spread across the desk, and his own reflection hangs in the black window above them.

And the thought he would not finish three nights ago -- the one he shut down in the dark glass before it could form -- finishes now. Ruth broke the last of it open. He looks at the man in the window, and this time he does not look away. And this time the quiet part comes out of him in words: low, rough, a man who has never once said a thing aloud saying the only thing left to say.

MARV
(barely)
...I'm gettin' out. Whatever it
takes. I'm gettin' out of it.

And saying it is deciding it. There is only the how left now.

He turns to Vern's papers -- read like scripture, for weeks. He has mapped what can be mapped: dates, routes, a shape.

Names he half-knows. And above Dutch, a blank: a shadow he can infer but never see, and never, ever reach.

There is no head to cut off, none he can find. So he turns instead to the one thing in this whole machine that is his -- the one body only he knows the location of. Deke.

MARV (CONT'D)
(quiet, working it)
...Can't reach the top of it.
But I can hand the law a body
that points the right way. Let
them do the digging I can't.

It is the plan of a man who has run out of every other kind.

CUT TO:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

The manila envelope, out of the drawer of unclaimed effects. Marv could not have said, the night he filled it, why he was filling it. The hands did the trade. That is all the reason they have ever needed.

Deke's pocket litter, laid out on the steel: a thin fold of bills. A pocketknife. Keys to doors that will never miss them. And a little spiral pad, curling at the corner -- names, sums, hours, all of it in Deke's blunt block hand.

Marv sets the pad beside a scrap of butcher paper, and begins to write. The same line, over and over. His own hand is thirty years of ledger copperplate, and he works it letter by letter until the copperplate dies out of it -- until what is left could have come off any wall in Moundsville.

From his coat, a matchbook. A bar across the water -- the one with the back booth, the one Dutch chose. He turns it over once and sets it with the rest.

Last, the dates. He counts backward, slow, the way he counts everything -- how long a man lies in frozen ground, and what the ground gives back, and what a coroner will read off the body. There is one night that fits. He writes it in Deke's hand: a time, and the name off the matchbook.

And there is the one thing in the man he cannot touch. It will come out on a steel table somewhere, measured and photographed and filed, and it will say what it says: a man was shot. It will not say by whom. That much the pockets have to do.

He looks at the small pile a long moment -- a man's whole exit, forged out of pocket litter. Then he puts on his coat.

CUT TO:

INT. SHERIFF'S STATION - BULLPEN - NIGHT (DEEP WINTER)

The map above Cody's desk has grown -- more folders, more pins, string strung between them. He hangs up a phone. The same dead end.

CODY
Ohio again. Real polite about
it.

HOLLIS
(pulling on his coat)
They always are. It's February,
kid. Go on home.

But Cody doesn't move.

CODY
Two weekends the state boys sat
on those crossings, Hollis.
Both bridges, dusk to dawn. Not
so much as a taillight out of
place.

HOLLIS
So there's nothin' movin' on
the river.

CODY
Or somebody knew they were
comin'.

HOLLIS
(shrugging into the coat)
Whole courthouse knew, kid. A
stakeout with a schedule ain't
a secret, it's an announcement.

And that is true enough that Cody lets it go. It does not
once occur to him to count the people he told. He only told
the one.

But Cody taps a new card pinned off to the side.

CODY

I still can't get this Whatley thing out of my head, Hollis.

HOLLIS

The Moundsville fella? Whose truck's been snowed under at the Legion for weeks?

CODY

That's the one. Still nobody's laid eyes on him. And it just won't sit still in me.

HOLLIS

Deke Whatley skippin' town owin' somebody money ain't exactly front-page.

CODY

(turning to the map)
No. Except a lowlife like that drops off the earth right in the worst stretch of ODs this county's ever seen -- and I can't quit turnin' it over. I keep gettin' the feelin' he didn't skip. That somebody tidied him up.

Hollis says nothing. Cody's back at the map -- the times, the dead.

CODY (CONT'D)

'Cause somebody's still bringin' it in, regular, right past every one of us -- and I can't find the hand doin' it. It's ridin' on somethin' that runs this valley, crosses that river, keeps whatever hours it likes, and not one of us ever once thinks to wave it down and look. Somethin' so plain the road just forgets it's there.

A silence. He is describing a thing no lawman alive would flag or paw through -- and the name that fits it does not come, because the name that fits it is the man who taught him to drive this county, the last thing in his life that still feels like home. The thought gets as far as the edge of him. And Cody -- good, decent, half in love with the man and never once calling it that -- does the thing this whole town does. He looks away from it.

CODY (CONT'D)
 (rubbing his eyes)
 ...Whatley, the poison, all of
 it. Feels like one thing. I
 just can't make it be one
 thing.

HOLLIS
 (a hand on his shoulder,
 heading out)
 Some things you never do get to
 the bottom of, kid. You just
 learn to live on top of 'em.

He goes. Cody alone under the lamp -- the map of the dead, the vanished man, the invisible carrier -- all of it one thing, exactly as he said, exactly where he will never let himself look.

CUT TO:

EXT. THE OLD FARM CEMETERY - NIGHT

The frozen back-slope again, the leaning nameless stones. Marv works alone with a shovel and a hooded lamp turned low. The ground fights him -- it has set like stone since he closed it, and every foot has to be taken back by force, his breath tearing white, his careful undertaker's hands blistering inside their gloves.

He has put a thousand people into ground like this. He has never once taken one back out. There is no rite for this. No gentleness, no gift he can carry to it -- only the shovel, the cold, and the awful private knowledge of exactly how deep he dug.

The blade strikes wood. He clears the lid by hand, and there is the plain box, no plate, no flowers, exactly as he left it. He kneels a moment in the open grave before he can make himself lift it.

Then he does. He takes Deke Whatley back out of the earth he

put him in -- the same two hands, the whole rite run backward, the obscene mirror of his trade. He works fast, and he does not look at the face. A man can only turn away from a face so many times before the turning-away is the whole of who he is.

CUT TO:

EXT. A COUNTY BACK ROAD - NIGHT

Far from that farm plot, on ground the county law is sure to comb, Marv lays the body where it will be found by morning.

He has done the rest of it already, in his own room, on his own steel: the ground washed out of the hair and out from under the nails, the clothes burned and swapped for the plain workclothes a funeral home keeps for the men nobody comes to dress, the seams gone over twice for the dirt that hides in seams. And the dark has settled in Deke where he lay all those weeks -- so the body goes down in the one attitude that agrees with it.

And then he does the thing only an undertaker would think to do. He knows what a dead man carries. He knows exactly what a coroner tips out of the pockets, and how a deputy reads it. So he curates. Back into the pockets goes a dead man's ordinary weight -- the fold of bills, the knife, the keys, the license with his own name on it -- everything a body ought to carry, and nothing that looks toward this town. And with them, the two things that were never Deke's to carry: a matchbook from a bar on Dutch's side of the river, and a scrap of paper in Deke's own blunt, block-lettered hand -- a night, a time that falls square on the night Deke died, and a place, over there.

Far down the road, a light. Two lights. Coming.

Marv straightens with a dead man at his feet and watches them grow. There is nowhere to put anything. There is no version of this that reads as anything but what it is. He does not move -- moving is the thing that gets a man looked at -- and he stands there in the dark doing the arithmetic of the rest of his life while the lights come on, and on.

Then, a few hundred yards short of him, they swing. Wide, unhurried, a turn a man takes every night of his life. A farm lane, a drive, a road that was always going to be there. The lights go away sideways through the trees, and the dark comes back, and the road is empty.

Marv lets out a breath he did not know he was holding, and goes back to the work.

Nothing a killer left behind. Just a small-time man who wrote down where he was headed the night he stopped coming home. Marv steps back and reads the body the way he has read ten thousand -- and for the first time in his life, he has made one tell a lie.

CUT TO:

EXT. THE RIDGE ROAD - DAY

Cruisers pulled up crooked on a gravel shoulder. Tape snapping in a cold wind. A county DETECTIVE (50s, been at it a lifetime too long) crouches over the body while a DEPUTY works the pockets. CODY stands a little apart, hands on his belt, looking down at a face he half-knows -- the small-timer he asked Marv about, not two weeks gone.

DEPUTY

(crouched at the body)
One shot. And he's froze
through -- could be two days
out here, could be two weeks.
Doc'll have to say.

(going through the
pockets)
Wallet's on him, license and
all. Deke Whatley, Moundsville.
Matchbook's from the Riverside
-- that's the far bank, river
city, not ours. And there's a
note on him: a time, and the
Riverside again.

CODY

That's about when his truck
quit movin'. Been sittin'
outside the Legion since.

DETECTIVE

(not bothering to stand)
So he drove across the water to
meet a man, and the man drove
him back in a ditch.
Congratulations, boys.
Everything worth findin' is a
river-city problem.

CODY

Body's on our side of the line.

DETECTIVE

Body's the only thing on our side of the line. His trouble, his money, his people, whoever he went to see -- all of it's over there. You want to spend your whole winter buildin' a case in another state, over some Moundsville lowlife nobody's even claimed?

He rises, knees cracking, already finished with it. Out here a dead small-timer with a sheet and cross-river friends buys about this much daylight and not one minute more.

DETECTIVE (CONT'D)

(a hand on Cody's shoulder, moving off)
Write it up, kick it over the river, let 'em lose it in a drawer. That's the job, son.

And they go, and the tape snaps, and the case walks east over the water exactly as it was built to. Only Cody stays a beat longer, looking down at the dead man. Something in him will not quite lie flat. This is the one -- the lowlife he'd half-tied to the poison in his own head, the same name he'd carried to Marv himself two weeks back and watched him shake off -- and here he is now, a body in the weeds, with a trail running straight across the water into the one place Cody will never be let to follow. His whole theory, confirmed and buried in the same breath. He cannot make it into anything. He just does not like the shape of it. Then he tugs his cap down and goes to write the lie up as truth.

CUT TO:

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - MARV'S OFFICE - NIGHT

The phone. Marv answers it the way he answers everything -- calm, already of use.

CODY (V.O.)

(tired, the end of a long day)
Marv, hey. It's Cody. You holdin' up out there? This winter's about done the whole

county in.

MARV

Gettin' by, Cody. Long as your mother keeps threatenin' me with casseroles.

CODY (V.O.)

(a tired laugh -- then it goes out of him)
...She is. Listen, though. That fella you never heard of -- Whatley? Turned up out on the Ridge Road this mornin'. Been dead a while.

Marv goes very still. His voice does not. It never does.

MARV

...Lord. What happened to him?

CODY (V.O.)

Got himself crossways with somebody over the river, looks like. Note in his pocket, the whole nine. It's a river-city mess -- county's already kickin' it across the water, glad to be shut of it.

(a beat -- quieter, and it is only kindness)
Sad thing, kinda. Nobody's even come askin' after him. Fella just stops, and the world don't even blink.

And it lands somewhere in Marv it was never meant to -- because Marv knows exactly why no one will come asking after Deke Whatley. It is the very thing that made him useful.

CODY (V.O.) (CONT'D)

So -- reason I'm callin'. Coroner'll cut him loose in a day or two, no family we can turn up. You mind comin' to get him when he does? Nobody else to call. And, well. It's what you do.

CODY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 (a tired half-laugh,
 softening)
 ...Startin' to thaw out there,
 finally. River is breakin' up.
 Felt almost like spring this
 mornin'. Been a long damn
 winter, huh, Marv.

It is what he does. Marv looks at the wall a long moment. He will be asked to collect the body he staged, and box it, and put it in the ground -- a second time, with his own two hands. The trade closing over his head like water.

MARV
 (even, kind)
 'Course. Send him over when
 they're done with him. I'll see
 he's looked after.

He sets the phone down. And then he waits for it all to come apart -- and it does not. A day passes. Then another. The law stays across the river, chasing a ghost through the bigger town. Cody suspects nothing. And slowly, for the first time since the leaves came down, Marv lets himself believe it: the wrong man is being hunted, in the wrong place. It worked. Something clenched in his chest for months begins, at last, to ease. He allows himself the relief. He thinks he has earned it.

CUT TO:

EXT. COUNTY ROAD PAST THREE SPRINGS CEMETERY - DAY

The thaw has found the hillside -- the snow gone patchy and grey, the ground showing through like something surfacing. And up on the rise, small against the wet morning, CAROL. At a new stone, clearing the winter off it with her bare hand.

She hears the hearse on the road below. Looks up. And raises one hand -- to the man who buried her boy right, the one kindness this winter did her.

Marv raises his off the wheel. He does not slow, and he does not look in the mirror after.

CUT TO:

INT. SHERIFF'S STATION - DAY

And the proof of it, across town: Cody alone at the corkboard, after hours. Pinned there -- the Whatley file, the bagged matchbook from the far bank, a photo of the note in the dead man's hand: a time, and a bar on the far bank. And the whole of it runs off the edge of the map, into another state, into a quiet man the Ohio boys sat with an afternoon and cleared before the coffee went cold -- a name nobody over there will say a word against. The only thread the winter left him, and it was never going to be a case. He has the far end of it and not the near. He rubs his eyes.

HOLLIS, coat on, stops in the doorway on his way out. He looks at the board a long moment -- the map, the strings, the winter's worth of nothing.

HOLLIS

It walked east, kid. Box it up.
County says so, and so do I.

(a beat -- then, on his
way out the door, to
nobody)

Thirty-one years I been doin'
this. Wife's got the stew on at
six whether I solved a damn
thing or not.

He does not say it unkindly. He goes. And Cody stands a while. Then he does it -- pin by pin, string by string, the Whatley file, the matchbook, the note. He packs the whole winter into a cardboard box and fits the lid on it, and carries it to the shelf where the county keeps the things it has decided not to know.

FADE OUT.

INT. COYLE & SON FUNERAL HOME - FRONT HALL - NIGHT

And then, one night, it comes -- a knock at the front door. One. Then a second. Unhurried. Polite. Patient. The most frightening sound that has ever come to Marv Coyle's door, because he already knows there is only one man in the world it could be.

Marv opens the door -- and DUTCH is already speaking, low and unhurried, stepping in past him, hat in hand, like a man continuing a conversation they had only paused. Marv gives ground without meaning to -- a step, then another, back into his own front hall. Dutch does not hurry. He never has to.

DUTCH

A body turned up on the Ridge Road with my whole side of the river in its pockets. The law came across the water -- polite, apologetic, a few questions they were half-sorry to be asking. Sat with me the better part of an afternoon.

He finds the good chair as he talks and lowers himself into it, unbothered, the way he settles into everything. Whatever relief was in Marv is gone as though it never was.

DUTCH (CONT'D)

But I've taken quiet suppers with the right people over there for thirty years -- and a dead nobody like Deke Whatley buys about an afternoon of anyone's attention, and not one minute more. So they went on home. And never once thought to turn around and look at you.

MARV

(careful -- for one breath he lets himself believe he has won)
...Then it's done. The law's across the river chasin' its own tail. It's over.

Dutch says nothing.

And it is the nothing that does it. Thirty years of reading rooms, and Marv reads this one.

MARV (CONT'D)

(quiet -- the realization arriving as he says it)
...If it was over, you'd have sent word. You wouldn't have come.

DUTCH

(a small nod -- almost approving)
That's the thing, Marv. You keep thinkin' the law was ever the one you had to fool.

(gently, the jaws
beginning to close)
That boy was in the ground. And
nobody in the whole turning
world knew where -- but the man
who put him there.

The floor goes out from under Marv.

DUTCH (CONT'D)
It was clever, I'll give you
that. Cost me an afternoon
across a table from the law --
first man in a long time to
manage that. The boy's own
hand, his own pockets.
Cleverest thing you ever did --
and all it did was sign your
name to a corpse, for an
audience of one. The law is
never going to find you. It
didn't have to. I already have.
And now everything you'd lay
down your life to protect --
your good name, that trusting
boy with the badge who won't
quit driving out here -- all of
it sits in my hand, to close
whenever it suits me.

And there it is. The gambit meant to free Marv has handed
Dutch the one thing he did not yet have: certainty. Not a
court's. His own. Marv is not out. Marv is owned, down to
the last inch.

A long silence in the dark hall. Marv sits in the ruin of it
-- Ruth's turned back, Cody in the noose beside him, the
plan in ashes, his name signed to a corpse, everything he
set out to save gone past saving. And in the hollow where
all of it used to be, something lets go, and goes still, and
cold.

A man with nothing left to protect becomes, at last, the one
thing Marv Coyle has never been in his life: unreadable. The
reader, gone blank. When he speaks again the fear has gone
out of his voice, and everything else with it.

MARV
(empty, calm)
So here's how it lies. I walk
away tonight, I never say a
word, you never lay eyes on me
again. That's one road.

DUTCH

And the other?

MARV

The other's the one where you decide I'm a loose end. Where I go quiet, like Vern. Like Deke.

(and here, the strangest calm)

But here's the thing, Dutch. I can't read you anymore. First time in thirty years I can't read a man in front of me. And you can't read me either -- because there's nothing left in me to take. You taught me every card in the deck. You just never once sat across from a man holding none.

DUTCH

(studying him -- and for the first time, we cannot tell what he finds)

...

MARV

Two roads. You pick.

Dutch regards him. A long moment, and then a longer one -- two readers, each for the first time a closed book to the other. Dutch's face gives away nothing at all. His hand rests easy on the arm of the chair.

He opens his mouth to answer.

CUT TO BLACK.

And the black holds. A long time -- longer than is comfortable. The length of a breath let all the way out, and not drawn back in.

FADE IN:

INT. ANOTHER FUNERAL HOME - PREP ROOM - NIGHT

Another town. Thirty, forty miles down the river -- far

enough that no living soul here has ever heard the name Coyle. A prep room like Marv's and nothing like it: newer, brighter, a busier man's shop. CYRUS (40s) works over a body with the unbothered ease of a man who has done this a thousand times and expects to do it a thousand more. He is not new to any of it. He has been at it a long while.

In the good chair, patient, a casket catalog open on his knee, sits DUTCH. Precisely as he once sat for Marv. Precisely as he must once have sat for a young man named Vern.

DUTCH
(turning a page, easy)
Two of the usual this week. And
one more besides.

CYRUS
(not looking up from the
work)
The usual's no trouble. Ohio
run?

DUTCH
Ohio run. Same as it always is.

(a small pause)
And then the one more. A
special. Needs to go quiet,
over the line. No name on him.
No stone. You understand me.

Cyrus glances at the second table -- a shape beneath a sheet. He does not lift it. He does not ask. He learned a long time back, the way they all learn, exactly what not to know.

CYRUS
(a nod, entirely
untroubled -- it is only a
Tuesday)
...Yes, sir. I'll take good
care of him.

Said now, by another man -- and Cyrus does not feel the weight of them at all, because to Cyrus there is no weight in them. There never has been.

DUTCH
(the ghost of something,

gone as fast as it comes)
I know you will.

CUT TO:

EXT. STATE LINE - NIGHT

Ahead, out on the highway, a state weigh station sits at the edge of the road -- lit sodium-yellow, the kind the long trucks pull into and idle and wait. The hearse is not a truck. It is nobody's freight, subject to nobody's scale. It holds its lane and rolls on past, unweighed and unremarked -- the way the dead move everywhere.

Nobody stops a man carrying the dead. Nobody ever has.

I/E. HEARSE - CONTINUOUS

Cyrus at the wheel. And behind him, a quiet passenger.

The hearse rolls through, into the dark. The taillights shrink. The fog takes them. Exactly as another pair did, on another night, before any of this ever began.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END.